

Contesting the Rules of the Game: Organized Groups in Election Policymaking

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Abstract

What draws organized groups into fights over election rules? Scholarship emphasizes two routes to policy influence: lobbying those in office and spending to shape who reaches it. I argue that groups also press for election rules that help elect candidates aligned with their broader goals. Yet we know little about how often they do so. Research has centered on Congress, though election rules are made in state legislatures, where systematic cross-state data are scarce. I assemble original data across 22 states, linking more than 11,000 election bills over three decades to positions in lobbying disclosures and committee testimony. To examine when groups enter these debates and how they try to shape policy, I introduce two measures. The first classifies whether bills expand or restrict voter access, built through a human-in-the-loop process combining large language models, supervised machine learning, and human validation. The second is, to my knowledge, the largest set of group ideology scores derived from state legislative activity. I find that group participation in election policymaking is widespread: nearly three in four positions come from groups whose primary policy areas are not elections. Engagement rises where elections are closely contested, where groups hold a legislative foothold, and on bills affecting voter access. Furthermore, failures to achieve desired policy outcomes further draws in groups with weaker presence. Liberal groups back expansive bills and conservatives restrictive ones. Where groups take opposing sides, roll-call voting is more partisan, and stark ideological divisions dampen enactment. These findings carry weight amid eroding election confidence and concern over democratic backsliding, showing how organized groups use election law as part of a broader political strategy.

Keywords: state legislatures, organized groups, lobbying, election policy

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“The pro-life movement must engage in election transparency and integrity reform or their ability to elect pro-life, pro-family lawmakers—and pass laws that save lives—will be greatly diminished, if not extinguished.”

—Ken Cuccinelli, National Chairman, Election Transparency Initiative

1 Introduction

Conflict over the rules and procedures of elections is a recurring feature of American politics. The aftermath of the 2020 presidential election, the storming of the U.S. Capitol on January 6, 2021, and recent fights over mid-decade redistricting and noncitizen voting have given these disputes renewed salience, but they have long shaped the evolution of American democracy. The post–Civil War franchise fights, the long struggle for women’s suffrage, the Progressive-era redesign of municipal elections, and the dismantling of Jim Crow through the Voting Rights Act of 1965 were all, at their core, fights over *who* may vote and what their votes could decide (Keyssar 2009; Valelly 2004; Bridges 1997). As Hasen (2014) argues, today’s “voting wars” are different. Alongside the perennial question of who may vote, contemporary debates now extend to the mechanics of election administration. Features once treated as neutral, almost bureaucratic matters of how elections are run have become opportunities for partisan advantage. In that sense, election law itself has become “part of a political strategy.”

Organized groups have been central to these conflicts. Suffrage associations organized to extend voting rights to women (McConaughy 2015; Teele 2018), the NAACP fought discriminatory barriers that denied Black Americans meaningful access to the ballot (Luders 2010; Francis 2014; Mickey 2015), and Progressive-era reform leagues redesigned municipal institutions and elections to combat corrupt political machines (Bridges 1997). In each case, groups pursued interests central to their organizational missions. In this paper, I demonstrate that a defining feature of election policymaking in the “voting wars” era is the involvement of a wider range of organized groups acting for more *instrumental* purposes. As illustrated by the quote above from Ken Cuccinelli, chairman of the Election Transparency Initiative launched by the anti-abortion organization Susan B. Anthony Pro-Life America, organized groups increasingly see the success of their policy agendas as tied to the rules for conducting

elections.¹ When groups act to shape those rules, they engage in what popular discourse might call *mission creep* and what, drawing on recent analyses of interest group behavior (Fagan, McGee, and Thomas 2021; Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz 2023), I term *out-of-portfolio participation*—groups taking action in policy areas outside the central focus of their work.

Existing scholarship on how organized groups pursue their policy goals has emphasized two strategies: lobbying (Hall and Deardorff 2006; Hansen 1991) and campaign contributions (Cassie and Thompson 1998; Welch 1980; Phillips 2024). I argue that groups today pursue a third, complementary strategy in shaping the rules governing who can vote, how ballots are cast, and how election results are determined. Favorable rules make it easier for a group's supporters to register, turn out, and cast ballots that count, raising the return on groups' investment in campaign mobilization (Rosenstone and Hansen 1993; Hansen 2016). Moreover, a contribution must be targeted to specific organizations or contests, but a change to election rules applies across many contests at once, helping some groups insulate their advantage or affording challengers new opportunities to gain power (Issacharoff and Pildes 1998). Favorable rules can likewise raise the returns to lobbying. By helping elect sympathetic legislators, they enlarge the set of officeholders to whom groups can supply the information and legislative labor that sustains lobbying as a subsidy (Hall and Deardorff 2006).

If election law has become part of a broader political strategy for organized groups, state legislatures provide an ideal setting for examining how that strategy operates. Under America's system of electoral federalism, state governments hold primary authority over the rules governing federal, state, and local elections. They are therefore a central venue through which groups seek to shape election policy, by testifying or lobbying for or against proposed bills. When groups whose core work lies in other policy areas take public positions on election bills, they make otherwise technical questions of election administration easier to interpret politically. Their positions signal to legislators that a proposal matters to a broader issue network (Lorenz 2020) and provide cues to the public, policymakers, and rival groups about its ideological and partisan implications (Zaller 1992; McDermott 2006; Boudreau 2009; Arceneaux and Kolodny 2009; Nicholson 2011).

Because shaping election rules is only one option on groups' menu for pursuing policy

1. See full press release about the launching of the Election Transparency Initiative [here](#).

influence, I argue that out-of-portfolio participation is conditional. Groups engage when they are sufficiently *motivated*, when proposed changes are *consequential* for electoral outcomes, and when they have an established legislative *presence* that lowers the cost of action. Groups are most *motivated* to act when they believe the existing political order works against them. In shaping election rules, they engage in what Riker (1986) called *heresthetics* (the art of political manipulation)—changing the terms of competition rather than playing within them. As Shepsle (2003) emphasizes, that incentive is unevenly distributed as groups the rules already favor defend them, while those that keep losing have the strongest reason to seek alternatives. Groups experiencing *legislative frustration*—a repeated failure to achieve their policy goals—should thus be especially likely to turn to election rules as a way of changing their fortunes. Motivation alone, however, is not enough. Since changes to election rules often have modest effects on their own (Grimmer and Hersh 2024), organized groups are more likely to participate where elections are closely contested, changes could plausibly tip the balance of power, and the stakes are most *consequential*. Finally, groups are more likely to act when they have an established legislative *presence*. Groups that already monitor bills, testify, lobby, or otherwise participate in a state’s policymaking process face lower marginal costs of taking one more position, even on election legislation outside their usual work.

These expectations frame the first of three research questions. First, under what conditions do groups whose core missions lie outside election administration engage with election legislation? To answer it, I assemble original data across 22 states, linking more than 11,000 election bills introduced over roughly three decades to the positions groups take as reported in records of lobbying disclosures and committee testimony collected in part by Hall et al. (2024). I find that out-of-portfolio participation in election policymaking is both widespread and conditional. Nearly three of every four positions come from groups acting outside their primary policy areas. Consistent with my argument, these groups engage more in states with closer elections and when they were more active in prior sessions. Legislative frustration matters too. Among groups with less established presence, those repeatedly on the losing side—supporting bills that fail or opposing bills that become law—are more likely to take action on election legislation.

Second, do groups take predictable positions when they engage? Answering this question

requires two new measures. The first is a measure of bill effects. I classify each bill by whether it expands or restricts access to the ballot, improves or weakens election administration, or has mixed or unclear effects, using a novel human-in-the-loop process that combines close reading, fine-tuned large language models, and supervised machine learning. The second is a measure of group ideology. I estimate group ideal points from their positions and legislators' roll-call votes using a Bayesian item response theory framework, producing what is, to my knowledge, the largest set of group ideology scores derived from state legislative activity. Together, these measures allow me to examine whether groups take positions aligned with the policies their broader ideological coalitions are presumed to benefit from. As expected, I find that liberal groups tend to support expansive or improving bills and oppose restrictive or weakening ones, while conservative groups do the reverse.

Finally, how does out-of-portfolio participation relate to the politicization of election policy? Using roll-call records and bills legislative histories, I examine whether the presence and alignment of out-of-portfolio groups track how differently Democratic and Republican legislators vote and whether bills become law. I find that when out-of-portfolio groups line up on opposing sides of a bill, partisan differentiation on its final-passage vote is roughly 15 percentage points higher. The relationship with enactment is less consistent. In the main analyses, whether a bill becomes law depends more clearly on its content and the partisan configuration of state government than on group participation itself, though additional analyses suggest that enactment is less likely when ideologically distant groups are arrayed against one another. Whether opposing groups drive legislators apart or instead gravitate to bills already likely to divide them is hard to disentangle. Either way, it is telling that groups recognize the most politicized election legislation and concentrate their efforts there. Their participation thus provides one of the clearest signals of where the partisan stakes of election policy lie.

Overall, this work has implications for the study of organized groups. Narrowly, it shows that out-of-portfolio participation, previously documented in Congress (Fagan, McGee, and Thomas 2021; Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz 2023; Furnas, Heaney, and LaPira 2019), is also a feature of state politics. It also sheds light on the strategic nature of group behavior, showing that groups do not enter every debate where they have an indirect stake but act selectively, joining when and where their efforts are most likely to matter. More broadly, this work speaks

to debates about democratic backsliding and the resilience of democratic institutions. Recent work places state governments at the center of these debates, showing how elected officials and coordinated, conservative-leaning policy networks use tools such as voter restrictions and gerrymandering to gain or preserve power (Hertel-Fernandez 2019; Grumbach 2022; Campbell and Karch 2026). My work documents the broader network of organizations involved shaping the rules of how elections are conducted. The actions of these groups matter precisely because their positions signal who stands to gain from proposed policy changes. Amid deep political polarization and partisan sorting, these signals carry particular weight as political elites decide whether to exploit opportunities to tilt elections to their advantage (Helmke, Kroeger, and Paine 2022). Because changes to election rules can be used alongside, or in sequence with, other institutional strategies for gaining power, fights over election policy can have consequences that extend beyond any single bill (Campbell and Karch 2026). Above all, treating election law as a political strategy shapes which reforms stay on the agenda and remain politically feasible. As administrative questions become partisan contests, reforms already working in other jurisdictions spread more slowly, leaving election officials less able to modernize and improve how elections are run (Hale and Brown 2020).

2 Theoretical Grounding

2.1 Political Parties, Organized Groups, and the Pursuit of Policy

A prominent theory of political parties argues that they are "best understood as coalitions of interest groups and activists seeking to capture and use government for their particular goals" (Bawn et al. 2012, pg. 571). In contemporary politics, the enactment of preferred policies constitutes the central "prize" these policy-demanding groups seek (Hacker and Pierson 2014). To this end, organized groups and activists work collectively to shape party agendas and governing strategies by exchanging information (Koger, Masket, and Noel 2009), reinforcing party messaging (Lee 2016), and influencing the nomination and selection of political candidates (Cohen et al. 2008; Bawn et al. 2012).

While organized groups attempt to shape political parties into their own vision, political parties themselves know that winning elections requires them to function as effective vehicles

for mobilizing supporters, communicating clear policy positions to the electorate, and maintaining a coherent and recognizable "brand name" (Aldrich 2011). Within legislatures, this requires parties to make use of institutional tools that structure the legislative agenda to protect party brands and legislative majorities, dynamics observed not only in Congress but also in state legislatures (Cox and McCubbins 2005, 2007; Cox, Kousser, and McCubbins 2010; Anzia and Jackman 2013). Additionally, this requires legislative parties to engage in public-facing activities that maximize differences in how parties are perceived by voters (Lee 2016).

Organized groups seeking to achieve their policy goals must determine how to proceed within this environment. Ultimately, their influence over policy outcomes—which appears substantial, at least in Congress (Burstein and Linton 2002)—may be manifested in a variety of ways, including setting policy agendas, defining policy alternatives, and shaping the implementation of enacted policies (Baumgartner and Jones 2009; Berry 2010; Patashnik 2003). Organized groups have a menu of options to choose from in pursuit of this influence. One such strategy is public position-taking on the policy questions put before government. Organized groups may file comments with government agencies (Kerwin and Furlong 2019) or serve on advisory committees (Balla and Wright 2001). They may also submit briefs to courts (Caldeira and Wright 1988) or participate directly in litigation (Olson 1990). In legislatures, groups may provide testimony or engage in lobbying in support of or opposition to specific legislative proposals. Such efforts may be directed toward legislators who already share a group's policy goals, supplying them with the resources needed to secure preferred outcomes (Hall and Deardorff 2006), or toward persuading legislators to adopt positions aligned with the group's interests (Hansen 1991). In doing so, groups work to broaden the coalition in support of their preferred policy outcomes and shape the content of proposals throughout the policymaking process (Hojnacki 1998).

Organized groups undertake a strategic calculus when selecting the most optimal venues and tactics for securing preferred policy outcomes, weighing their own capabilities and those of their competitors (Holyoke 2003). One component of this calculus is the decision over *which* policies groups choose to take action on. On the one hand, groups may concentrate their efforts narrowly on government actions that directly affect the core of their policy portfolios—that is, the policy areas in which they most frequently operate and that are central to their

organizational mission. Indeed, specialization remains a central organizational strategy: groups cultivate reputations by serving as primary advocates on particular issues (Browne 1990), which can attract investments from supporters (Berry and Schildkraut 1998) and establish them as reliable information providers to policymakers (Hayes 1981).

On the other hand, the changing nature of policy and politics incentivizes groups to act broadly and engage in debates on government action outside of the core of their policy portfolios—what I term "out-of-portfolio group participation." Modern American policymaking is shaped by broad "issue networks" of groups, a consequence of government interventions that increasingly cut across policy areas (Heclo 1990). The "politicization of organizational life" (pg. 89) accompanying this expanding scope of government action has drawn more groups into policy debates. As policies generate differential effects across constituencies, groups mobilize—often in partnership with allied groups (Laumann and Knoke 1987; Hula 1999; Nownes 2000)—around particular problems and may shift their focus across policies in response to the political stakes created by government action.

Consequently, as allied groups repeatedly coordinate their efforts and work together, they build relationships with actors whose support advances their policy goals. These relationships are increasingly structured by the networks of groups and activists that make up party coalitions, particularly in an era of intense political polarization. As party competition intensifies, the stakes of political outcomes increase and uncertainty about future policy grows, creating stronger incentives for groups to engage with and align themselves alongside these coalitions (Gray et al. 2015). Parties, in turn, draw groups into policy conflicts outside of the core of their policy portfolios: aligned groups develop shared electoral incentives and take positions that reinforce the party's brand, sustain its governing coalition, and enhance its electoral prospects (Fagan, McGee, and Thomas 2021). Participation across a broader set of policies also reflects the reciprocal nature of coalition membership, as groups support their allies in expectation of future cooperation. Over time, this repeated coordination fosters a shared view of coalition success, with groups taking cues from fellow members about when and where their engagement can most effectively advance both collective and their own policy goals. Groups that participate across a wider range of policies can also build ideological credibility, helping policymakers interpret policy debates through a particular ideological lens

(Heaney 2004). More simply, out-of-portfolio participation can signal commitment to the shared goals of the party coalition and reinforce a group's standing as a reliable partner—a signal especially valuable in a context of partisan conflict, where legislators seek allies who are clearly aligned with their broader agendas (Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz 2023).

Within the realm of state politics, having access to legislators is important for groups. With rising polarization nationally and legislative gridlock at the federal-level, more attention has been paid to policymaking at the state-level (Grumbach 2018, 2022). In many policy areas, including education, criminal justice, and social policy, states play a leading role in initiating policy change (Moncrief and Squire 2021). In the vein of Louis Brandeis's famous metaphor that states are "laboratories of democracy," states are often originators of the policies and politics that come to shape national politics (Garlick 2023). Yet despite their policymaking power, state legislators face relatively weak electoral accountability, as voters rarely sanction them for poor substantive representation, in part due to low media coverage, uncompetitive districts, and voter inattention (Rogers 2017, 2023). Because partisan control of state government increasingly translates into distinct policy outcomes, particularly in polarized contexts (Caughey, Warshaw, and Xu 2017), the stakes of state-level politics are high for organized groups. This environment of low accountability heightens the influence of organized and ideological groups, which are better equipped than voters to monitor legislators and coordinate cohesive policy agendas across states (Hertel-Fernandez 2019). In some states, groups can exert influence over the policy agenda directly by even drafting legislation themselves (Kroeger 2022). In this context, out-of-portfolio group participation becomes especially useful at the state level, as clear signals of commitment to a party coalition help groups sustain access to legislators and position their policies as priorities within the coalition's broader agenda.

In short, in a time of political polarization and partisanship, out-of-portfolio participation allows organized groups to build cooperative relationships with allied groups and reinforce the coalitions and party brands that increasingly shape policy outcomes. This strategy is effective in helping groups achieve their desired policy outcomes through two mechanisms. First, by demonstrating that proposed changes serve the interests of a diverse coalition (or a broad issue network), group activity signals to legislators that a proposal commands support beyond a

narrow set of stakeholders (e.g., organized groups whose work focuses only on voting rights or election integrity), underscoring the importance of advancing it through the legislative process (Lorenz 2020). Second, public position-taking becomes an elite cue to help shape public opinion on complex policy areas (Zaller 1992; Lupia 1994). Group endorsements and opposition also serve as heuristics that help the public, policymakers, and other stakeholders infer the ideological or partisan implications of policy proposals (McDermott 2006; Boudreau 2009; Arceneaux and Kolodny 2009), particularly when those implications are not readily apparent (Nicholson 2011).

Nevertheless, existing literature has primarily emphasized campaign contributions as a key strategy through which organized groups exert influence. Some organized groups are *access*-oriented and target incumbent officeholders regardless of party affiliation, hoping to build relationships with those in government who can advocate for their desired policy outcomes. Others are *ideological* and target aligned candidates to shape the composition of government (Cassie and Thompson 1998; Welch 1980). As Phillips (2024) shows, it is this latter, ideological strategy that drives parties toward their ideological extremes, with groups increasingly adopting such approaches as policy areas become more politicized (Barber and Eatough 2020). Yet the effectiveness with which campaign contributions translate into favorable electoral outcomes is situated within the broader set of rules and procedures that govern American elections. For those *ideological*-oriented groups seeking to shape who is elected, this creates an additional opportunity: to engage in public position-taking on election reform proposals that structure who can vote, how votes are cast, and how votes are counted. By supporting or opposing changes to election policy that may affect the likelihood that their preferred candidates are elected, out-of-portfolio participation on election legislation becomes a means of securing the representation that advances groups' broader policy goals.

2.2 Election Policy and the Structure of Political Conflict

Because electoral rules determine how political power is allocated, conflict over the design and implementation of election policy are often characterized as redistributive and zero-sum in nature (Tsebelis 1991; Bowler and Donovan 2013). Therefore, political elites approach election

policy with an awareness of the partisan advantages (or disadvantages) that changes may produce (Boix 1999; Colomer 2004). For this reason, electoral systems and rules have been described as "the most specific manipulative instrument of politics" (Sartori 1968, pg. 273).

Under America's system of electoral federalism, state legislatures exercise primary authority over the rules and procedures that structure the conduct of elections. Because of shared electoral incentives offered to groups in coalition with one another, they may wish to take positions on state election legislation, particularly in contexts where even marginal changes are perceived as consequential for electoral outcomes. From this perspective, group action on election policy reflects an effort to alter the political environment in which future policy debates take place, or more specifically, to achieve the representation necessary to achieve desired policy outcomes in the future. By taking positions on election policy, groups participate in what Riker (1986) termed *heresthetics*—the art of political manipulation.

While primarily defined by state legislatures, changes to electoral policy may shape political representation in federal, state, and local institutions. This underscores the incentives for groups to engage in debates on election policy as part of a broader effort to influence the distribution of political power. Examples of these efforts by organized groups and their implications are numerous. Coalitions supporting state-level voting rights legislation in Connecticut, Maryland, and Michigan—composed of labor unions, faith-based organizations, disability advocates, and community groups—frame their advocacy in terms that explicitly connect state reforms to anticipated conflicts over voting rights at the federal level.² As supporters of the Maryland Voting Rights Act argue, "the best way we can prepare for attacks on voting rights and democracy at the federal level is to pass the Maryland Voting Rights Act now," underscoring how state-level reforms are viewed as part of a broader strategy over national political conflict. Similar dynamics were evident in high-profile conflicts over mid-cycle redistricting in 2025. In Texas, opposition to HB 4 drew testimony from labor unions, civil rights organizations, faith communities, and voting rights groups, while California responded by advancing AB 604, its own redistricting measure, backed by an equally broad coalition spanning organized labor,

2. See the list of organizations signing a letter in support of the [Connecticut State Voting Rights Act](#) (SB 1226, 2023), [Maryland State Voting Rights Act](#) (SB 342, HB 983, SB 685, 2025), and [Michigan State Voting Rights Act](#) (SB 401, 2024).

reproductive rights advocates, and immigrant-serving organizations.³ Planned Parenthood, for instance, framed their support of AB 604 explicitly in zero-sum terms, describing Texas's redistricting effort as an attempt to "rig" the 2026 midterm elections and characterizing AB 604 as California's opportunity to "check the Trump administration's encroachments on civil rights and individual freedoms."⁴ That the prospect of one state gaining a partisan advantage in congressional representation was sufficient to mobilize broad opposition within one state and prompt countermeasures in another illustrates the zero-sum logic that drives organized groups into election policy conflicts outside the core of their policy portfolios.

Groups also engage with electoral rules that shape representation in local government. Teacher unions, for instance, have opposed efforts to consolidate school board elections with higher-turnout contests, recognizing that off-cycle elections amplify their influence and increase the likelihood of electing candidates who support policies such as higher teacher pay (Anzia 2011, 2014). In 2022, Portland, Oregon considered charter amendments adopting ranked-choice voting and multi-member city council districts. These reforms were made possible by state legislation enacted in prior years and drew support from a coalition of labor unions, civil rights organizations, environmental groups, and immigrant advocacy organizations.⁵ Similarly, the Sierra Club testified in support of legislation requiring that newly certified voting systems be capable of administering ranked-choice elections, framing the reform in terms of its expected benefits for the representation of women and people of color.⁶ In each case, groups engaged in debates in pursuit of election rules that might bring about the descriptive representation needed to advance their substantive policy goals.

While the benefits of taking positions on election legislation may seem clear, organized groups must still weigh real costs. Position-taking in the form public lobbying or legislative testimony requires time and organizational resources and may entail reputational risks. These costs are not uniform: groups already embedded system affording groups opportunities to interface with policymakers possess the infrastructure, relationships, and familiarity needed to engage in out-of-portfolio participation. I thus argue that when organized group activity

3. See the list of organizations represented as witnesses in hearings on [Texas HB 4 \(2025\)](#) and whose positions are recorded on [California AB 604 \(2025\)](#).

4. See quote from the California State Assembly's [Floor Analysis](#) of AB 604.

5. See the list of endorsing organizations at [Portland United for Change](#).

6. See [testimony](#) provided in support of Maryland HB 334 (2023).

election legislation is conditional. Groups engage when they are sufficiently *motivated*, when proposed changes to election policy appear *consequential* for electoral outcomes, and when they have an established *presence* before government that lowers the marginal costs of action.

Although these factors should shape engagement on election reforms across levels of government, *state* politics provides the most tractable setting for assessing when groups choose to do so. This is due in part to the central role of states under American electoral federalism, as well as their broader importance in the making of public policy. With rising polarization and gridlock at the federal level, states have become key arenas for policymaking across a wide range of issues, from education and criminal justice to social policy (Grumbach 2018, 2022; Moncrief and Squire 2021). State-level policy innovations frequently set the template for national politics (Garlick 2023), making control of state government a valuable prize for organized groups. That prize is made more attainable by the weak electoral accountability that characterizes state legislative politics: voters rarely sanction legislators for poor substantive representation, leaving organized groups—better equipped to monitor legislators and coordinate cohesive agendas—with substantial opportunities to shape policy outcomes (Rogers 2017, 2023; Hertel-Fernandez 2019). In short, the central role state legislatures play in shaping both election rules and substantive public policy makes them an especially useful setting for understanding when and why organized groups turn to election policy as instrument for achieving their goals.

2.3 Expectations and Implications of Group Action on Election Policy

The *motivation* to shape election policy should be greatest among groups that experience *legislative frustration*—that is, groups that frequently find themselves on the losing side of policy debates (Baumgartner and Jones 2009; Mahoney 2008). When groups repeatedly fail to achieve their policy goals, election policy becomes an attractive venue for heresthetics, offering a path to reshaping who governs rather than continuing to fight losing battles under the current composition of government. Once groups achieve their goals on election legislation and reshape the rules of the game to their benefit, however, they should be less likely to take action in the future. Motivation alone, however, is insufficient. Although changes to election

policy often have modest or ambiguous effects on outcomes (Grimmer and Hersh 2024), these effects become more meaningful where elections are closely contested. Under greater *electoral competition*, changes to election rules may tip the balance of power, raising the stakes of election legislation for groups on both sides and increasing the incentive to take positions. Finally, because groups with an established legislative *presence* (i.e., those that regularly engage in the policymaking process) face lower marginal costs of participation, they should be more likely to take positions on state election legislation.

These same dynamics also structure the positions groups take when they engage with election legislation. Because organized groups are often incentivized to align with a party, group positions on election policy in state legislatures should follow clear partisan patterns. The two major parties have staked out sharply opposing stances: the Democratic National Committee has championed expansive reforms—automatic voter registration, expanded early voting, and voting rights protections—while the Republican National Committee has emphasized electoral integrity concerns and supported voter identification requirements.⁷ These divisions have become especially salient in the wake of the 2020 U.S. election, as disputes over election administration, rising election litigation, and a surge in state-level election legislation have only reinforced these partisan divisions (Hasen 2022; Grumbach and Hill 2023). Groups aligned with each party should adopt corresponding positions, supporting changes they expect to advantage their coalition and opposing those that threaten it. The conventional wisdom that Democrats favor *expansive* election policies while Republicans favor more *restrictive* ones should thus map onto the positions of aligned groups, even as some work suggests the traditional electoral logic underlying these party stances may be weakening (Stephanopoulos 2025). More concretely, *liberal* groups are expected to favor *expansive* election policies, while *conservative* groups are expected to favor more *restrictive* ones. This reflects the partisan coalitions with which organized groups are aligned and the electoral conditions under which their preferred candidates are expected to prevail.

The larger implications of out-of-portfolio group participation lie in the legislative outcomes it helps produce. When ideologically distinct groups line up on opposing sides of election

7. See [2020 Democratic Party Platform](#) and [2016 Republican Party Platform](#). Stark (2026) provides an extensive analysis of how election administration has become a major policy issue for both parties over time.

proposals, their position-taking clarifies the partisan stakes of legislation. Helmke, Kroeger, and Paine (2022) show that as social groups sort into opposing partisan camps, electoral rules generate asymmetric partisan advantages, revealing ostensibly technical reforms as contests over political power. By making the partisan stakes of election bills legible to legislators, organized groups thus transform what might otherwise appear as administrative policy into a broader conflict over future political competition. Election legislation attracting polarized group coalitions is therefore expected to be associated with more partisan legislative voting. At the same time, group position-taking operates within institutional constraints, as agenda control, sponsorship coalitions, and bill content shape which proposals advance (Cox and McCubbins 2007, 2005; Anzia and Jackman 2013). Consequently, group activity may affect how legislators engage with election policy without fully determining whether legislative proposals ultimately become law.

3 Data

Examining when and how group participate in election policymaking, as well as the consequences of their participation, requires data on both the legislation introduced in state legislatures and the positions organized groups take on that legislation. This section provides an overview of how relevant legislation is identified and classified, how legislative records are collected, and how group positions are captured using committee testimony and lobbying disclosures.

3.1 Election Legislation

Identification and Collection To identify election legislation introduced in state legislatures, I rely on legislative trackers produced by the National Conference of State Legislatures (NCSL) and the Voting Rights Lab (VRL).⁸ In these trackers, each bill is tagged with its date of introduction and coded for the specific areas of election policy it affects. For the

8. Legislation introduced between 2001 and 2010 are identified by a legislative log provided by NCSL staff. Legislation introduced between 2011 through 2024 are collected from the NCSL's "[State Elections Legislation Archived Database](#)" and the VRL's "[State Voting Rights Tracker](#)." Any legislation included in this study that was introduced prior to 2001 was identified using legislative journals produced by state legislatures. More information on the identification and categorization of election legislation is found in Appendix Section A.

purposes of analysis, in this paper, I collapse the policy area labels used by these trackers into seven categories. These categories are designed to capture substantively distinct aspects of election policy while remaining comparable across states and time. Specifically, I code legislation as affecting: *Absentee Voting and Vote-by-Mail*, which includes rules governing eligibility, application, distribution, and return of ballots; *Administration*, covering the organization, funding, and responsibilities of election officials and election workers; *Election Integrity*, encompassing procedures for ballot counting, audits, recounts, election security, and enforcement of election laws; *Logistics*, including the timing and conduct of elections, polling place locations and hours, early voting, and voter information; *Voter Identification*, such as identification and proof-of-citizenship requirements; *Voter Registration*, including eligibility, registration methods, and list maintenance; and *Campaigns and Parties*, which captures rules governing candidate ballot access, party organization, permitted campaign activities, and primary elections. For each piece of legislation, I collect its full text and information on bill sponsorship (e.g., whether a bill is sponsored by a Democratic or Republican legislator), legislative status (e.g., whether the bill is enacted into law), and, where available, roll-call voting.⁹

Evaluating the Effect of Election Legislation Understanding how election legislation is likely to be perceived by relevant stakeholders and policymakers requires assessing how proposed changes would alter existing election policies within a state. I adapt the classification taxonomies used by James and Stewart (2022) and the Voting Rights Lab, which rely on close readings of legislative text, with particular attention to provisions that insert, amend, or delete language in existing election statutes. After evaluating each bill in its entirety, I classify legislation according to its effect on voter access and the quality of election administration.¹⁰ Bills are coded as *Expansive/Improves* if they lower barriers to participation or enhance the capacity or professionalization of election administration, *Restrictive/Worsens* if they raise

9. For legislation introduced after 2009, these data are drawn from records compiled by [LegiScan](#). For legislation introduced prior to 2009, the information is obtained either from the replication data provided by Bucchianeri, Volden, and Wiseman (2024) or through original data collection from legislative information sites maintained by individual state legislatures. More information on legislative record collection is found in Appendix Section B and details on the collection of legislative text is found in Appendix Section C.1.

10. More information on the rating schema used is found in Appendix Section C.2.

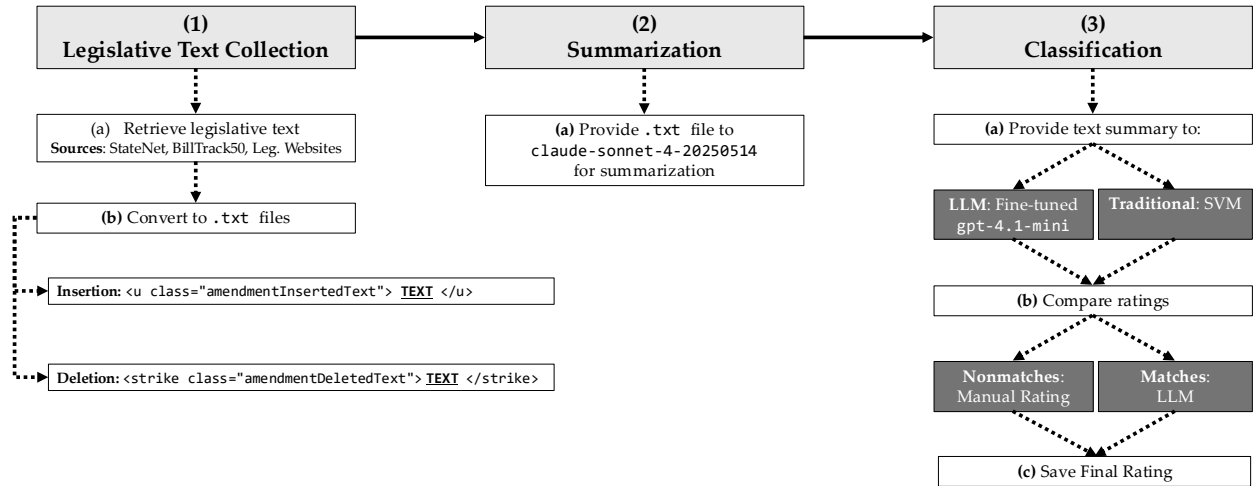


Figure 1: **Automated Approach for Evaluating the Effect of Election Legislation.** Outlines the three-step process for an automated text-based method for classifying legislation as *Expansive/Improves*, *Restrictive/Worsens*, *Mixed/Unclear*, or *Neutral*.

barriers to participation or diminish administrative quality, *Mixed/Unclear* if they combine offsetting effects across policy areas or consist primarily of narrow technical changes with unclear implications, or *Neutral* if they do not affect the policy areas examined in this study. Ratings are assigned based only on provisions affecting voter access and the administration of elections. Thus, *Campaigns and Parties* provisions are excluded from the rating process.

To scale the process of evaluating legislation, I follow the procedure outlined in Figure 1. When legislation amends existing law, state legislatures use a variety of conventions to indicate inserted and deleted statutory language.¹¹ After obtaining the legislative text in Step (1a), I preserve any formatting that distinguishes new language from language removed from existing law. In Step (1b), I convert the text—whether retrieved as HTML or PDF—into plain text files. During this conversion, I apply state-specific markup rules to standardize how insertions and deletions are represented across states. In Step (2), the plain-text files for each piece of legislation are provided to a large language model (LLM) for summarization. Prior work shows that LLMs perform well on summarization tasks, though they remain susceptible to hallucinations (Goyal, Li, and Durrett 2022; Zhang, Yu, and Zhang 2025). I use Anthropic’s *claude-sonnet-4-20250514* model, which has been shown to produce summaries with higher human-like quality relative to comparable models (Janakiraman and Ghoraani 2025).

11. See the NCSL’s *Types of Markup Used in Bills* guide.

The model was instructed to produce a concise, content-only summary describing how the legislation alters existing election law, with particular attention to statutory language that is inserted into or removed from current policy, as indicated by formatting preserved during the text conversion process.¹²

In Step (3a), the legislative summaries are provided to both a fine-tuned large language model (LLM) and a supervised support vector machine (SVM) model for multi-output classification for evaluation.¹³ Prior to model training, a team of research assistants reads and evaluates a random sample of legislation using the full text of each piece of legislation. These manually coded texts form the training, validation, and test sets for the classification task. Using the training data, OpenAI's gpt-4.1-mini model is fine-tuned, and the SVM is trained, to assign an overall rating for legislation. In Step (3b), the ratings generated by the two models are compared. When the models disagree, a team of research assistants manually assigns ratings. When the models agree, the ratings from the fine-tuned LLM are used. Thus, the final ratings used in this study compiled in Step (3c) are produced using a "hybrid approach" in which multiple automated classifiers are used to detect classification uncertainty, with human coders intervening in cases of disagreement, consistent with the approach advocated for by Heseltine and Von Hohenberg (2024).

3.2 Group Positions

To identify whether organized groups support or oppose legislation, I rely on records from the Dataset on Policy Choice and Organizational Representation in the United States (CHORUS) (Hall et al. 2024), along with committee records collected from legislative information sites in additional states that document group positions in committee bill analysis reports and hearing minutes. A summary of these records is presented in Table 1.¹⁴ As shown, these data cover 22 states beginning as early as 1995 and vary along key dimensions, including partisan control,

12. More information on the standardization of legislative text and the creation of legislation summaries is provided in Appendix Section C.1.

13. More information on this approach, a comparison of alternative models, and evaluation metrics for these ratings are presented in Appendix Section C.3.

14. More information on how data on group positions was collected is found in Appendix Section D.1.

Table 1: Data Collection and Record Coverage for Group Positions

State	Record Type	Chambers	Coverage Begins	Source	Bills Introduced	Bills with Positions	Avg. Positions
AZ	Testimony	Both	2006	CHORUS	1,043	434	7.22
CA	Testimony	Both	1995	Legislature	1,034	637	8.32
CO	Lobbying, Testimony	Both	2003	CHORUS	117	113	23.39
FL	Testimony	House	2004	CHORUS	264	43	6.42
IA	Lobbying	Both	2009	CHORUS	243	239	8.74
IL	Testimony	Both	2013	CHORUS	584	166	9.89
KS	Testimony	Both	2014	CHORUS	193	56	8.11
MA	Lobbying	Both	2010	CHORUS	547	202	2.84
MD	Testimony	Both	2020	CHORUS	264	215	4.98
MO	Testimony	Both	2003	CHORUS	766	108	4.38
MT	Lobbying, Testimony	Both	2006	CHORUS	155	35	7.20
NE	Lobbying	Unicameral	2000	CHORUS	188	163	6.88
NJ	Lobbying	Both	2014	CHORUS	927	205	2.29
NV	Testimony	Both	2001	Legislature	296	140	10.10
OH	Testimony	Both	2015	CHORUS	112	44	16.36
OR	Testimony	Both	2013	Legislature	259	99	5.62
RI	Lobbying	Both	2018	CHORUS	328	93	2.58
SD	Testimony	Both	1997	CHORUS	143	101	2.83
TX	Testimony	Both	1997	CHORUS	2,438	633	20.82
UT	Testimony	Both	2002	Legislature	342	177	2.89
WA	Testimony	Both	1995	Legislature	949	426	3.89
WI	Lobbying	Both	2002	CHORUS	589	323	4.98

Note: Records with "CHORUS" as the source were collected by Hall et al. (2024). Records with "Legislature" as the source were collected from committee reports made publicly available on state legislative websites.

electoral competitiveness, and legislative professionalization.¹⁵ They also differ in whether group positions are observed through lobbying disclosures or committee testimony. In either case, these records capture public and costly acts of position-taking by organized groups. These data thus omit other forms of engagement, such as press statements, online advocacy, or private coalition activity in which only some organizations bear the costs of public-facing activity. While this limitation constrains the scope of group behavior observed in this study, it implies that any effects that are found likely understate the extent to which organized groups engage in election policy debates.

Across all analyses in this study, I use the last position—either support, oppose, or neutral/monitoring—taken by the group on a given piece of legislation. In some cases, groups change their positions as legislation is amended over the course of the legislative process. By focusing on a group’s final position, these analyses are most likely to reflect groups’ assessments of legislation in its final form, as well as the positions legislators observe when they determine whether or not legislation should become law.

For Wisconsin, I supplement group positions records collected by CHORUS with legislation-level lobbying effort data from the Wisconsin Ethics Commission’s lobbying disclosure system.¹⁶ Registered groups are required to report the time their lobbyists devote to specific legislative proposals in semi-annual filings, and because groups may register positions on legislation without devoting lobbyist hours, these records allow me to distinguish pure position-taking from costly lobbying activity. I use these data to measure the total hours each group spends on election legislation relative to all other legislation introduced in a session, capturing the intensity of group participation and the costs some groups choose to incur when acting on election policy.

Given that group position records are compiled from 22 states, I take great care to standardize organization names across states. This ensures that group participation can be tracked consistently within and across states over time. Using this standardized list of group

15. See Appendix Table D-4 for a comparison of sample states to all states on key political and institutional characteristics. Appendix Figure D-1 displays the variation in partisan control, electoral competitiveness, and legislative professionalization within each state included in the sample.

16. See <https://lobbying.wi.gov/Home/Welcome>. More information on these data are found in Appendix Section D.2.

names, I add three pieces of metadata.¹⁷

First, I classify each group by organizational type as either *Advocacy*, *Government*, or *Political*.¹⁸ The analyses presented in this study focus on *Advocacy* and *Political* organizations.

Second, I identify whether elections constitute a group's primary policy area or whether it falls outside the core of their policy portfolio (referred to as out-of-portfolio groups).¹⁹ Groups whose primary policy area is classified as *Civil Rights & Constitutional Issues* or *Elections & Voting* are treated as election-focused in this study.

Lastly, to measure group ideology, I construct ideal point estimates based on groups' positions across all legislation introduced in the states included in this study.²⁰ Following Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz (2020), I estimate a Bayesian item response theory (IRT) model that jointly scales groups' support and opposition positions with legislators' final-passage roll call votes on the same pieces of legislation.²¹ Models are estimated separately within each state on a vote matrix pooling group and legislator positions across legislative sessions. To ensure that these estimates are identified on a common left-right dimension and are comparable across states, I anchor the scale using the minimum, median, and maximum common space scores for Democratic and Republican legislators from Shor and McCarty (2011) and Shor (2025). I then project the resulting state-specific group scores onto the Shor-McCarty common space using Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression, allowing group ideology to be interpreted consistently across states.²²

17. More information on the creation of group metadata is found in Appendix Section D.3.

18. *Government* organizations are those whose primary role is to carry out or support governmental functions (e.g., state agencies, professional associations of government officials). *Advocacy* are organizations promoting the interests of issues or specific groups (e.g., issue-based interest groups, nonprofits, labor unions). *Political* organizations primarily include state and local party organizations and affiliated party committees. This classification is conducted primarily through keyword-based rules, with remaining or ambiguous cases categorized using a prompt to OpenAI's gpt-5-mini model.

19. CHORUS provides industry codes for organizations drawn from the FollowTheMoney database. I combine these industry codes with information on the legislative subject area in which groups most frequently take positions across all legislation introduced within the states and years covered by this study to determine a group's primary policy area.

20. Details on the construction and tests for the validity of group ideal point estimates are presented in Appendix Section D.4.

21. Roll-call voting data are drawn from LegiScan and cover legislation introduced since 2009.

22. This approach is similar to Thieme (2020), who use lobbyist declaration data to jointly estimate interest group and legislator ideal points via IRT in Iowa, Nebraska, and Wisconsin. My scores are constructed using data from a mixture of legislative testimony and lobbying records from 22 states. Given the scope of my data, rather than bridging observations using groups that take positions in multiple states or using candidate responses to the Political Courage Test, I use anchor scores within each state to the Shor-McCarty common space scores to enable comparisons across states.

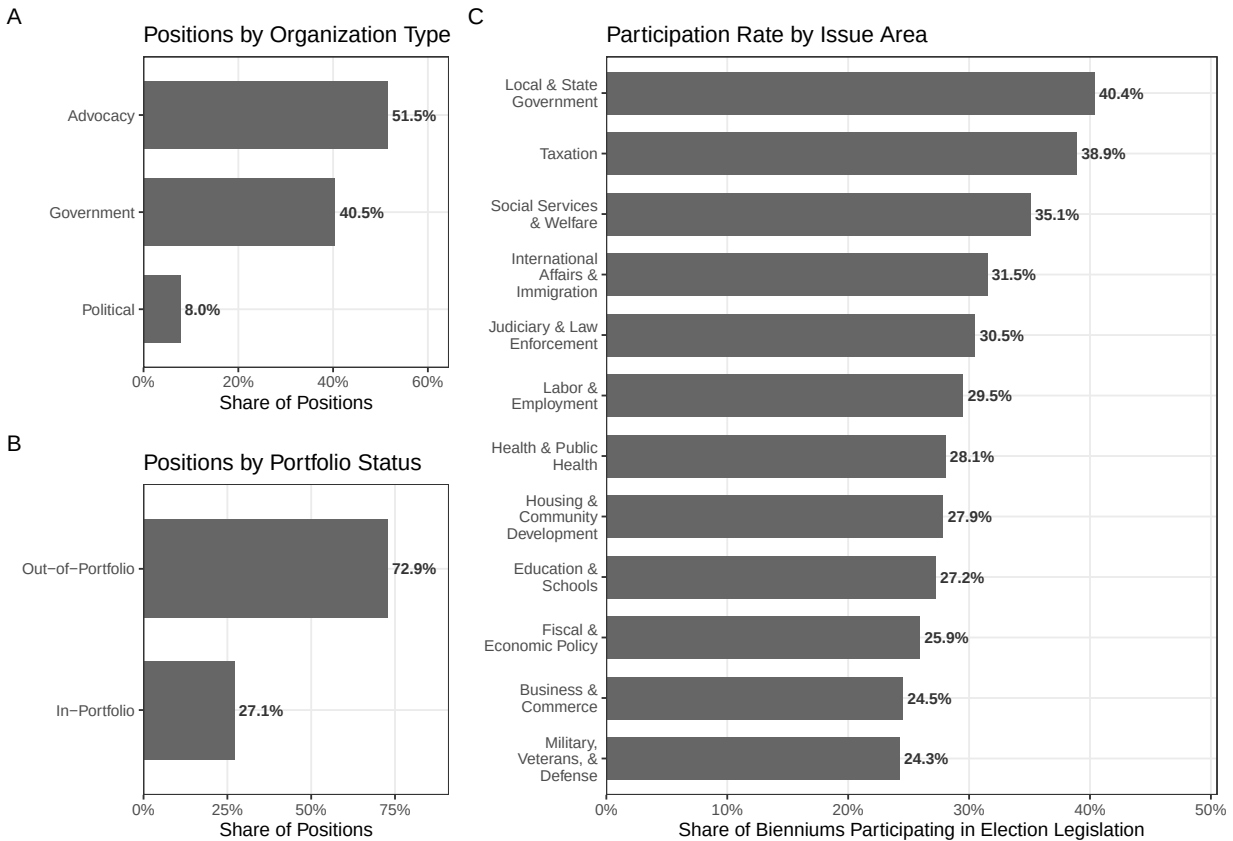


Figure 2: Summary of Groups Taking Action on State Election Legislation. Panel A displays the proportion of all positions by advocacy, government, and political groups, respectively. Panel B displays the proportion of positions from out-of-portfolio versus in-portfolio (groups whose primary policy areas are *Civil Rights & Constitutional Issues* or *Elections & Voting*). Panel C displays the average share of legislative bienniums in which out-of-portfolio groups participated in election legislation, by primary policy area. For simplicity, only the top twelve policy areas are displayed.

4 Analysis

In this section, I provide analyses that (1) examine the out-of-portfolio groups that take action on election policy, (2) the conditions in which they take action, (3) the substantive positions they take on legislation proposals, and (4) the effects of their participation on legislative outcome. For each analysis, I present both the methodological approach and their corresponding results.

4.1 Which Organized Groups Participate in Election Policy?

Before examining what drives organized groups to engage in out-of-portfolio participation on state election legislation, I first provide an overview of the ecosystem of groups that take part in lobbying or providing testimony on election reform proposals in [Figure 2](#). As shown in Panel A, governmental representatives—including election officials, city clerks, and legislators—account for 40.5% of total recorded positions. The remainder consists of advocacy and political groups, which are the focus of this paper. Among these non-governmental actors, Panel B shows that only 27.1% of recorded positions come from in-portfolio groups whose primary policy focus is election policy itself. This means that when legislators receive input from organized groups on state election legislation, nearly three in four positions come from groups whose core mission lies elsewhere—underscoring the prevalence and potential importance of out-of-portfolio participation.

Panel C highlights that the primary policy areas represented by the groups taking action on state election legislation are not limited to just a few. Displaying the average share of legislative bienniums (the two-year periods state legislatures typically operate on) in which out-of-portfolio groups from each policy area participated in election legislation, Panel C shows that groups from a wide range of policy domains—including the policies that characterize the bulk of what subnational government work on like taxation, social services, labor and employment, and law enforcement—regularly engage in election-related debates. In many cases, participation rates approach or exceed 30 percent of bienniums, indicating that engagement with election policy is a recurring feature of group activity. Taken together, these patterns underscore that out-of-portfolio participation is not confined to a narrow set of actors.

4.2 When Do Organized Groups Participate in Election Policy?

Having established that groups from a range of policy areas engage with state election legislation, I now turn to the question of *when* they participate. To do so, I construct a panel dataset in which each observation corresponds to a group-state-biennium combination. For each group, I identify all states in which it was active. Groups enter the panel in each state beginning with the biennium that contains either the start of the state’s data coverage window

or the group's first observed year of activity in any state included in my data, whichever comes later. Once a group has entered the panel, any bienniums in which the group took no position are coded as non-participation rather than missing, so each group is observed in every state-biennium in which it could have participated. This structure allows me to model participation as a function of time-varying group and state characteristics, leveraging variation within groups over time and across states. This panel setup is used in each of the following three analyses.

4.2.1 Electoral Competition and Out-of-Portfolio Participation

Using this panel, I examine the effect of electoral competition on a group's propensity to take action on election legislation in a given biennium. I estimate a fixed-effects linear probability model with the following specification:

$$\text{Participation}_{gst} = \beta_1 \text{Competition}_{st} + \alpha_g + \gamma_s + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{gst}. \quad (1)$$

$\text{Participation}_{gst}$ takes a value of 1 if group g took a position on at least one piece of election legislation introduced in state s during biennium t , and 0 otherwise. Competition_{st} is defined as one minus the average margin of victory in the most recent presidential and gubernatorial elections in the state, capturing how closely contested recent statewide elections were.²³ Group fixed effects (α_g) ensure that identification comes from within-group changes in participation over time, while state (γ_s) and biennium (δ_t) fixed effects account for persistent differences across states and common temporal shocks. I estimate this specification first for participation on any election legislation, then separately for participation on legislation pertaining to each major aspect of election policy (e.g., absentee and mail voting, voter identification).

I summarize the results of these models in [Figure 3](#), which displays how an increase in statewide electoral competition from 0.5 to 1 (i.e., from a 50-point margin of victory to a tied election) alters the average predicted probability that a group takes action on election legislation in a given legislative biennium.

23. A fixed-effects logit model would be more appropriate given the binary outcome, but conditional maximum likelihood estimation precludes the calculation of quantities of interest such as predicted probabilities, so I use a linear probability model instead.

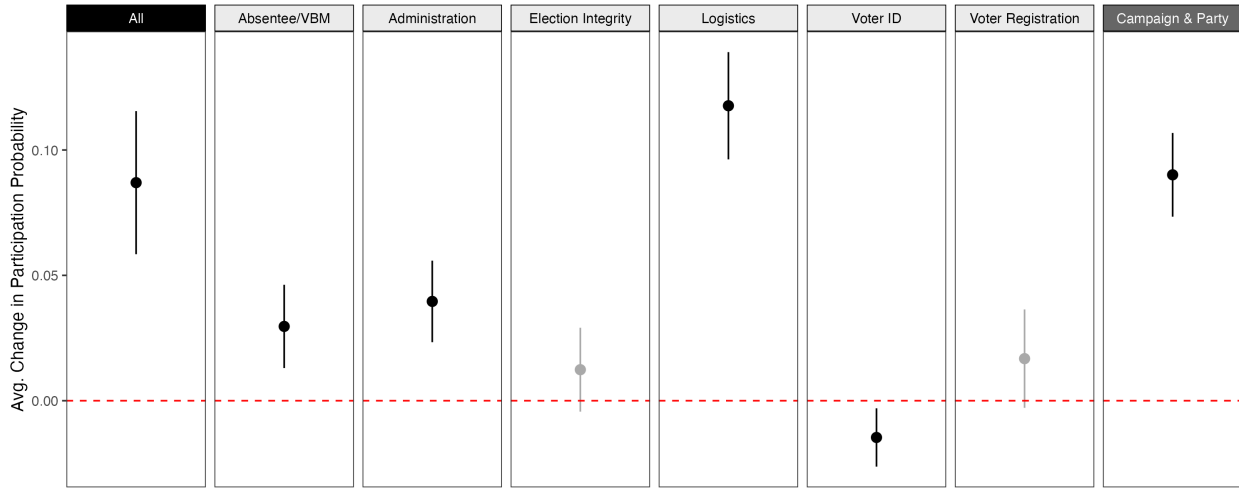


Figure 3: Average Marginal Effect of Increased Electoral Competition on Out-of-Portfolio Group Participation. Points show the average change in the predicted probability that a group takes a position on election legislation associated with an increase in electoral competition from 0.5 to 1. The first panel reports effects pooled across all election legislation; subsequent panels report effects by policy area. Models follow Equation 1 with standard errors clustered by group. See Appendix Table E-5 for model estimates.

As shown, statewide electoral competition is a statistically significant predictor of out-of-portfolio participation across *all* election legislation: an increase from 0.5 to 1 in the competition measure is associated with an 8.7 percentage point (pp) increase in the probability that a group takes action on election legislation in a given biennium. Groups are thus significantly more likely to engage in states and bienniums where recent statewide elections were closely contested, suggesting that out-of-portfolio participation is strategic—groups mobilize when electoral stakes are highest and the perceived impact of election policy is greatest. This pattern holds across several specific areas of election policy, with statistically significant positive effects for *Absentee Voting and Vote-by-Mail* (3.0 pp), *Administration* (4.0 pp), *Logistics* (11.8 pp), and *Campaigns and Parties* (9.0 pp). The exception is *Voter Identification*, for which competition is associated with a small *negative* effect (−1.5 pp). Voter ID legislation features among the most overtly partisan and racially charged debates in election policy (Bentele and O’Brien 2013; Hicks et al. 2015; McKee 2015; Biggers and Hanmer 2017), and several dynamics likely suppress out-of-portfolio participation in competitive environments. First, competitive legislatures are less likely to produce voter ID legislation in the first place, as Bentele and O’Brien (2013) find that more evenly divided chambers are associated with

fewer restrictive laws passed. Second, the extreme partisan polarization of votes on these bills (Biggers and Hanmer 2017) reduces the marginal gains of group engagement when majority control is uncertain. Third, the reputational costs of taking action cut in both directions as groups inclined to oppose voter ID requirements risk defying the broad public support they consistently attract (Alvarez et al. 2011; Kane 2017; Gronke et al. 2019; Stewart 2025), while groups inclined to support them risk appearing in support of racially-motivated voter suppression.

In Appendix Section E.1, I present two supplemental analyses that provide broader context for these results. First, Figure E-3 displays the same competition comparison for participation across all election legislation, separately for in-portfolio and out-of-portfolio groups. Participation by in-portfolio groups is even more strongly predicted by competition, suggesting that groups generally are more motivated to engage when electoral rules have greater potential to shape outcomes. Second, Figure E-4 presents marginal effects from models interacting Competition_{st} with Post-2020_t , an indicator for the period following the 2020 U.S. election. Prior to 2020, competition generally predicted greater out-of-portfolio participation across areas of election policy. After 2020, these effects attenuate or disappear in several areas—most notably *Campaigns and Parties* and *Administration*—while remaining robust for *Logistics* and *Absentee Voting and Vote-by-Mail*. Notably, the negative pre-2020 effect for *Voter ID* reverses sign and becomes positive and significant, consistent with the nationalization of election integrity debates in the post-2020 period. Together, these results suggest that the post-2020 period reorganized rather than simply heightened the role of competition in groups' decisions to take action on state election legislation, sustaining or strengthening its effect in areas that became focal points of popular discussion while attenuating it elsewhere.

4.2.2 Legislative Presence and Frustration as Determinants of Participation

While competition explains when groups find it advantageous to act on election policy, legislative frustration and presence explain why they do so. Keeping the same panel structure and model strategy, I examine two independent variables: (1) Lag Success Rate $_{g,t-1}$, measuring legislative frustration, defined as the share of positions group g took in biennium $t - 1$ whose

Table 2: **Legislative Frustration and Presence as Predictors of Out-of-Portfolio Group Participation in Election Policy**

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Lag Success Rate	0.008 (0.009)	0.005 (0.009)	−0.037* (0.017)	
Lag Success Rate (Elections)				−0.074* (0.036)
Lag log(Positions)		0.067*** (0.005)	0.053*** (0.008)	0.107*** (0.019)
Lag Success Rate × Lag log(Positions)			0.024* (0.010)	
N	17 849	17 849	17 849	1865
R-squared	0.315	0.331	0.331	0.477
FE: Group	X	X	X	X
FE: Biennium	X	X	X	X
FE: State	X	X	X	X

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Standard errors clustered by group.

outcome matched its position (i.e., supported bills enacted, opposed bills not enacted); and (2) $\text{Lag log(Positions)}_{g,t-1}$, measuring presence, defined as the log of the total number of bills on which group g took a position in biennium $t - 1$.²⁴ Because lower success rates indicate greater frustration, I expect a negative relationship between $\text{Lag Success Rate}_{g,t-1}$ and participation in election policy. Because groups do not necessarily take action on election legislation in every biennium within a state, there is missingness in the lagged variables, which reduces the sample size of these models.

Table 2 presents the results. Columns (1) and (2) show no direct effect of legislative frustration on out-of-portfolio participation: the coefficient on $\text{Lag Success Rate}_{g,t-1}$ is small and statistically indistinguishable from zero, regardless of whether presence is included. In contrast, presence is a strong and consistent predictor as groups with larger legislative footprints are substantially more likely to engage in election policy.

The picture changes once I allow the effect of frustration to vary by presence. Column (3)

24. Because groups do not take action on election legislation in every biennium within a state, the lagged variables contain missing values, thus reducing sample size.

shows that the coefficient estimate on $\text{Lag Success Rate}_{g,t-1}$ turns negative and significant, while the interaction with $\text{Lag log(Positions)}_{g,t-1}$ is positive and significant.²⁵ Together, these estimates indicate that legislative frustration motivates out-of-portfolio participation primarily among groups with *low* legislative presence. In other words, groups that have not been successful in attaining their desired policy outcomes and have not fully developed up a breadth of operations within a state are more likely turn attention to election policy. For high-presence groups, by contrast, participation in election policy does not depend on recent policy losses, but instead reflects their efforts to preserve the political environment they are already embedded in.

Finally, to underscore that out-of-portfolio participation is strategic, column (4) presents estimates using a measure of legislative success restricted to election policy alone. The results show that groups that are more successful in attaining their preferred election policy outcomes in one biennium are less likely to take action in the next. This pattern indicates that engagement with election policy is not constant, but rather reflects a strategic calculus—groups mobilize when opportunities arise, but step back once election policy has been shaped to their benefit.

4.2.3 Case Study: Lobbying Hours in Wisconsin as a Measure of Participation Costs

The analyses above measure participation as a binary outcome—whether a group took a position on election legislation at all in a legislative biennium. Frustration, however, may shape not just whether take action on election legislation, but how hard they work once they do. Wisconsin’s lobbying disclosure system records the total hours groups spend lobbying on each bill, allowing me to examine whether frustrated groups invest more effort in out-of-portfolio participation on election policy. To examine this, I run fixed effects regressions on the following outcomes: (1) $\text{Participation}_{gt}$, as before; (2) $\text{Prop. Allocated}_{gt}$, the share of a group’s total lobbying hours dedicated to election legislation; and (3) log(Hours)_{gt} , the log of total hours

25. To examine whether *capacity* rather than *presence* is a more appropriate predictor of participation, in Appendix Table E-6 I present results from models that include a group’s logged revenue and total assets (as reported in their IRS Form 990) as covariates.

Table 3: **Predictors of Election Lobbying Activity Among Out-of-Portfolio Groups in Wisconsin, by Biennium**

	Participation	Prop. Allocated	log(Hours)
Lag Success Rate	−0.037* (0.017)	−0.009 (0.006)	−0.118** (0.045)
Lag log(Total Hours)	−0.005 (0.005)	−0.001 (0.001)	−0.009 (0.017)
Lag log(Total Positions)	0.017+ (0.010)	0.001 (0.004)	0.033 (0.032)
State Government: Republican Trifecta	0.034** (0.011)	0.005+ (0.003)	0.077** (0.027)
N	2356	2163	2356
R-squared	0.518	0.337	0.304
FE: Group	X	X	X

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001
Standard errors clustered by group.

spent lobbying on election legislation. I use the following specification:

$$Y_{gt} = \beta_1 \text{Lag Success Rate}_{g,t-1} + \beta_2 \log(\text{Total Hours})_{g,t-1} + \beta_3 \log(\text{Total Positions})_{g,t-1} + \beta_4 \text{Republican Trifecta}_t + \alpha_g + \varepsilon_{gt} \quad (2)$$

with group fixed effects and standard errors clustered by group and where Lag Success Rate_{g,t-1} is defined as before for measuring legislative frustration, log(Total Hours)_{g,t-1} represents the total number of hours group *g* spent lobbying in the previous biennium, log(Total Positions)_{g,t-1} is defined as before for measuring presence, and Republican Trifecta_{*t*} is an indicator of whether Wisconsin was under a unified Republican government in biennium *t*. I omit biennium fixed effects to preserve identification of the trifecta indicator.

The results in Table 3 are consistent with the frustration mechanism. As shown, groups with higher success rates in previous bienniums are less likely to take action on election legislation (column 1) and, conditional on participating, spend substantially fewer hours on election lobbying (column 3).²⁶ The lack of statistical significance in column 2 suggests that legislative

26. Appendix Table E-7 shows that the result in column 3 is robust when including biennium fixed effects to the model.

frustration drives *additional* effort toward election legislation rather than a reallocation from other areas. The fact that the indicator for a biennium being under a Republican trifecta predicts greater participation and effort across all three outcomes is consistent with the heightened mobilization around election legislation during periods of unified Republican government that occurred in the early 2010s. Together, these results underscore that legislative frustration shapes not just whether groups engage in out-of-portfolio participation on election policy, but how much effort they are willing to expend when they do. Groups that are losing elsewhere are not merely showing up, they are working harder to shape the rules for future electoral competition.

4.3 Do Groups Take Expected Positions on Election Legislation?

Having shown that organized groups are more likely to engage with state election legislation under conditions of electoral competition, legislative presence, and, in some cases, legislative frustration, I now turn to the question of *which* positions they take. If groups behave strategically and view expansive election policies as benefiting liberal coalitions and restrictive policies as benefiting conservative ones, we should expect these patterns to be reflected in their decisions to support or oppose individual pieces of legislation.

To examine this, I run two sets of models that take advantage of both the election legislation effect classification and the group ideology scores introduced in this paper. First, I run a linear regression of a group's net restrictive lean—defined as the share of its positions that are pro-restriction (supporting restrictive legislation or opposing expansive legislation) minus the share that are pro-expansion (supporting expansive legislation or opposing restrictive legislation)—on its estimated ideology score. This produces a cross-sectional, group-level measure of ideological alignment in position content. I estimate the model separately for all groups, out-of-portfolio groups, and in-portfolio groups. Second, I estimate a series of two-way fixed effects models in which the outcome is whether a group supports (versus opposes) a piece of election legislation, conditional on taking a clear support or oppose position rather than a neutral or monitoring one. I estimate these models separately for expansive, restrictive, and mixed/unclear legislation, interacting group ideology with an indicator for the partisan control

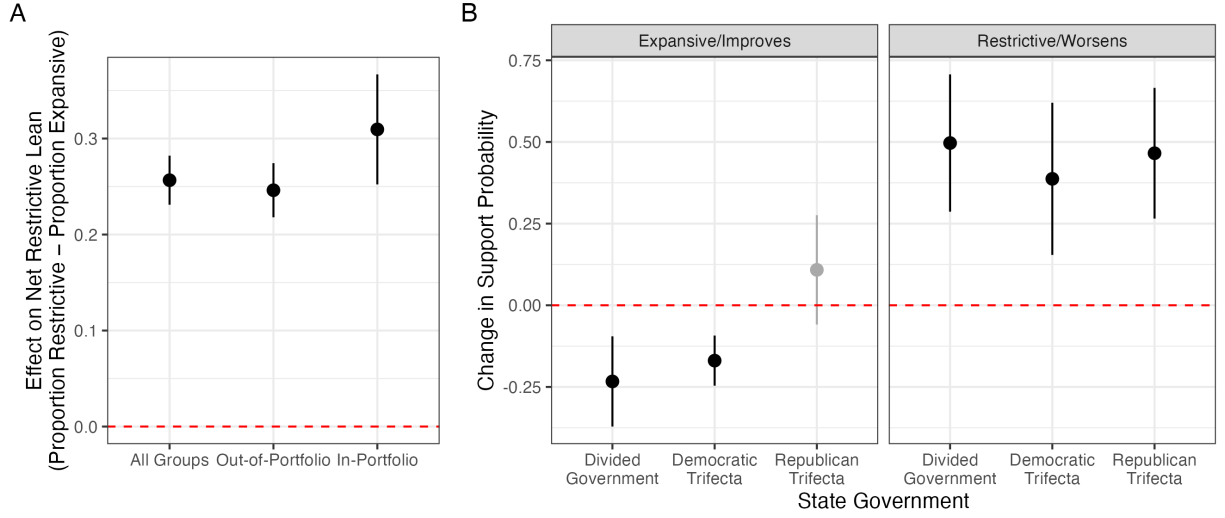


Figure 4: **Position-taking of Organized Groups on Election Policy.** Panel A displays the effect of a one-standard deviation increase in a group’s ideology score (toward the more conservative direction) on the net balance of a group’s positions that are restrictive versus expansive, estimated separately for all groups, out-of-portfolio groups, and in-portfolio groups (see full estimates in Appendix Table E-8). Panel B displays the effect of a one-standard deviation increase in a group’s ideology score on the probability of supporting (versus opposing) election legislation, by state government type; facets provide estimates separately for expansive and restrictive legislation (see full estimates in Appendix Table E-9).

of state government in the legislative biennium (divided government, Democratic trifecta, or Republican trifecta). I use the following specification:

$$\text{Support}_{bgt} = \beta_1 \text{Ideology}_g + \beta_2 \text{Trifecta}_{st} + \beta_3 (\text{Ideology}_g \times \text{Trifecta}_{st}) + \eta_b + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{bgt} \quad (3)$$

where Support_{bgt} is an indicator equal to one if group g supports bill b in biennium t (and zero if it opposes), Ideology_g is the group’s estimated ideology score (in standard deviation units), Trifecta_{st} captures partisan control of state s in biennium t , η_b are legislation fixed effects, and δ_t are biennium fixed effects. The first model serves in part to validate the group ideology scores while benchmarking the relationship between ideology and position direction for out-of-portfolio groups versus in-portfolio groups advocating for voting rights or election integrity. The second model examines whether this ideological alignment is conditioned by the content of legislation and the partisan control of state government.

Figure 4 summarizes the results of these two models. Examining Panel A first, it is quite

clear that group ideology is strongly predictive of the relative balance of restrictive versus expansive positions groups take. Across all groups, a one-standard-deviation increase in group ideology—where positive values indicate a more conservative group—is associated with a 25.7pp increase in a group’s share of positions that are pro-restriction positions compared to pro-expansion positions. For out-of-portfolio groups, this shift is associated with a 24.6pp increase. For in-portfolio groups the effect is somewhat larger, at 31.0pp. These results establish that ideology shapes the overall direction of group position-taking on election legislation. The question is whether this relationship is consistent across legislation and political context.

Panel B helps answer this question. Beginning with the right facet, which examine support for restrictive legislation, it is evident that groups’ responses to restrictive election legislation fall along expected ideological lines: more conservative groups reliably support such proposals, while more liberal groups consistently oppose them, regardless of partisan control of state government. In the left facet which focuses on *Expansive/Improves* legislation, the story is slightly different. A one-standard deviation increase in group ideology is associated with a 23pp and 16.9pp decline in the probability of taking a supportive position under divided government and Democratic trifectas, respectively. By contrast, there is no comparable or statistically significant relationship under Republican trifectas. In other words, in states where Republicans control both the legislature and the governorship, liberal and conservative groups support legislation that expands voter access and improves election administration at roughly similar rates. This asymmetry across levels of partisan control underscores the strategic nature of group behavior on election legislation: while expansive reforms may be perceived as electorally consequential under divided government or Democratic control, their perceived electoral implications are perhaps more muted when state government is firmly Republican.

Finally, I explore how motivation, operationalized as legislative frustration, shapes the relationship between ideology and the positions groups take on state election legislation. If liberal and conservative groups stand to benefit most from expansive and restrictive policy, respectively, then groups that have been least successful in advancing their legislative goals may be most likely to fall back on ideologically consistent positions. That is, frustration should amplify the relationship between ideology and position direction—groups with the lowest prior success rates should show the strongest alignment between their ideology and the content of

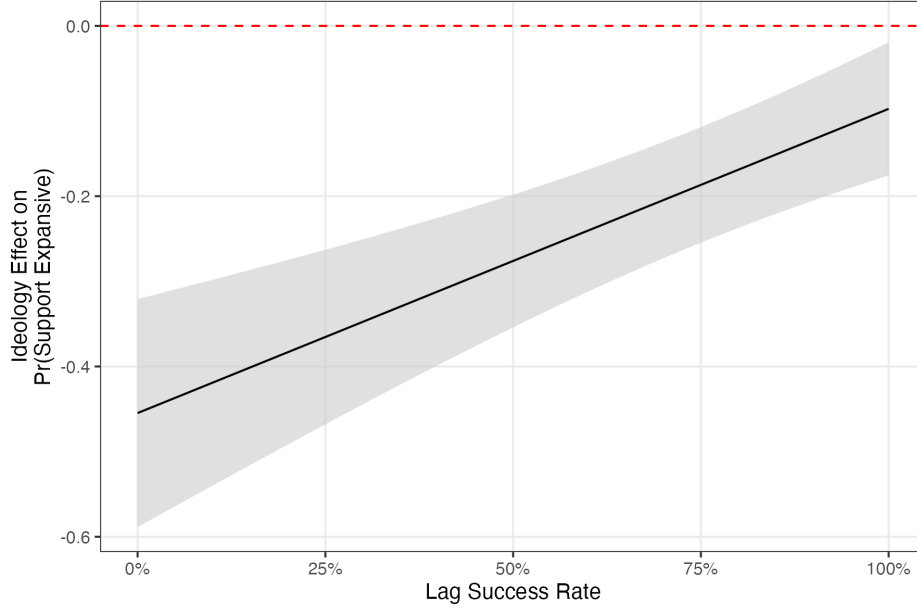


Figure 5: **The Effect of Group Ideology on Pro-Expansion Position-Taking, by Prior Legislative Success Rate.** Plots the marginal effect of a one-standard-deviation increase in group ideology (toward the more conservative direction) on the probability of taking a pro-expansion position (supporting expansive or opposing restrictive legislation) as a function of a group's prior legislative success rate, among out-of-portfolio groups only. Estimates are derived from Model 3 in Appendix Table E-10.

the positions they take. To examine this, I run another fixed effects linear probability model in the form of:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Pro-Expansion}_{bgt} = & \beta_1 \text{Ideology}_g + \beta_2 \text{Lag Success Rate}_{g,s,t-1} \\ & + \beta_3 \text{Ideology}_g \times \text{Lag Success Rate}_{g,s,t-1} + \eta_b + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{bgt} \end{aligned} \quad (4)$$

where $\text{Pro-Expansion}_{bgt}$ is an indicator equal to one if group g takes a pro-expansion position on bill b in biennium t (and zero if it takes a pro-restriction position), Ideology_g is the group's estimated ideology score, $\text{Lag Success Rate}_{g,s,t-1}$ is defined as before, η_b are legislation fixed effects, and δ_t are biennium fixed effects.

Figure 5 summarizes the result of this model. At the 25th percentile of prior success (38%), a one-standard-deviation increase in group ideology is associated with a 32.1pp decrease in the probability of taking a pro-expansion position. This effect attenuates to 27.6pp at the median (50%) and 22.1pp at the 75th percentile (65%). The difference between the slope at the 25th and 75th percentiles is 9.9pp and statistically significant ($p < 0.001$), indicating that prior legislative

success does in fact meaningfully moderates the relationship between ideology and positions groups take. Legislative frustration thus shapes not only *when* groups engage with election policy, but also *how* they engage when they do: groups that have been most unsuccessful in advancing their broader policy goals are most likely to take positions on election legislation that reflect their ideological interests.

4.4 How Does Group Participation Shape Legislative Outcomes?

Finally, I turn to an examination of the consequences of out-of-portfolio group on the legislative deliberations of state election policy, focusing on two outcomes. First, I consider whether legislation is signed into law with Enacted_{bst} , which equals 1 if legislation b introduced in state s and year t becomes law, and 0 otherwise. Second, I examine whether out-of-portfolio group participation is associated with greater partisan differentiation in legislative voting. Following Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz (2020) and Garlick (2022), I construct a roll call measure capturing the extent to which Democratic and Republican legislators vote differently from one another on final-passage votes for election legislation. For each vote, I first calculate party unity for party P , defined as $\text{PU}_P = \frac{V_{YP} - V_{NP}}{V_{YP} + V_{NP}}$, where V_{YP} denotes the number of "yea" votes cast by members of party P and V_{NP} denotes the number of "nay" votes cast by members of party P .²⁷ This measure ranges from -1 (complete party unity in opposition) to 1 (complete party unity in support). I then define $\text{Party Differentiation}_{bst} = \frac{|\text{PUD} - \text{PUR}|}{2}$, which ranges from 0 (identical voting across parties) to 1 (maximal partisan separation).

I model both outcome variables using fixed-effects linear regression of the following specification:

$$Y_{bst} = \beta_1 \text{Prop. Out-of-Portfolio}_b + \beta_2 \text{Diff. Positions}_b + \beta_3 \text{Bipartisan}_b + \beta_4 \text{Rating}_b + \gamma_s + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{bst} \quad (5)$$

where $\text{Prop. Out-of-Portfolio}_b$ is the share of positions on bill b taken by out-of-portfolio groups, Diff. Positions_b indicates whether out-of-portfolio groups take positions on both sides, Bipartisan_b indicates bipartisan sponsorship, and Rating_b classifies legislation as

27. As Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz (2023) note, PU_P itself is a modified version of the metric used by Rice (1925).

Table 4: Effects on Legislative Outcomes

	Party Diff.	Enactment
Prop. Out-of-Portfolio	0.059*	0.024
	(0.027)	(0.024)
Diff. Positions	0.149***	−0.038
	(0.038)	(0.041)
Bipartisan	−0.174***	0.091*
	(0.025)	(0.034)
Bill Type: Restrictive/Worsens	0.186**	−0.120***
	(0.058)	(0.025)
Bill Type: Expansive/Improves	0.062	−0.028
	(0.059)	(0.029)
State Government: Democratic Trifecta		0.083*
		(0.034)
State Government: Republican Trifecta		−0.028
		(0.036)
N	1165	3163
R-squared	0.410	0.174
FE: State	X	X
FE: Biennium	X	X

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001
Standard errors clustered by state.

Expansive/Improves, *Restrictive/Worsens*, or *Mixed/Unclear*. For enactment models, I add $\text{Party Trifecta}_{st}$ to account for unified partisan control. All models exclude legislation rated *Neutral*.

In the first column of Table 4, I examine how various factors affect how partisan final-passage roll call votes on election legislation are. Two aspects of out-of-portfolio group participation are positively and significantly associated with greater partisan differentiation. First, compared to legislation where no positions come from out-of-portfolio groups, legislation in which all positions come from out-of-portfolio groups see roll-call votes that are 5.9pp more partisan in final-passage voting. Second, when out-of-portfolio groups take positions on both sides of legislation, partisan differentiation in final-passage voting increases by approximately 14.9pp. Notably, this effect is similar in magnitude—though opposite in direction—to the

depolarizing effect of bipartisan sponsorship. As before, these results suggest important differences in the valence of restrictive versus expansive election legislation. Expansive legislation does not generate significantly greater partisan differentiation than mixed legislation, while restrictive legislation produces roll-call votes that are 18.6pp more partisan, consistent with restrictive proposals carrying a more negative valence. The second column of [Table 4](#) turns to whether these same factors predict whether election legislation is enacted into law. In contrast to the roll-call results, neither the proportion of positions taken by out-of-portfolio groups nor the presence of both supportive and opposing out-of-portfolio positions is predictive of enactment. Instead, whether election legislation is enacted is largely driven by features of the legislation itself, including who sponsors it and what it proposes to do to voter access and election administration in a state, along with partisan control of state government.

In Appendix [Table E-11](#), I examine the role of group ideology in shaping partisan legislative dynamics. My findings suggest that election legislation on which out-of-portfolio groups are, on average, more liberal elicits greater partisan differentiation in roll-call voting. Moreover, greater ideological distance between out-of-portfolio groups supporting and opposing legislation is associated with heightened legislative partisanship, consistent with the idea that conflict between groups reinforces partisan voting behavior. As shown in Appendix [Table E-12](#), this ideological division also reduces the likelihood legislation is enacted. Thus, while the mere presence of disagreement between groups does not reduce the likelihood of enactment, the strength of this disagreement does.

In all, these results suggest that out-of-portfolio groups shape how contested election legislation becomes rather than whether it ultimately succeeds. Put differently, group participation appears to contribute to the politicization of election policy without systematically producing legislative gridlock for election reform. Given the nature of the data and models presented here, I cannot rule out that these results suffer from a reverse causality explanation. It might simply be the case that these groups are aware of the partisan implications of proposed legislation and join the fray accordingly. However, the timing of group engagement is informative. Among bills with full legislative histories and recorded position dates, a plurality of groups (32.1%) typically take their position between committee referral and the first recorded vote, 9.3% do so before referral, and 16.6% engage between the first recorded vote and final

passage. Groups thus tend to weigh in early in the legislative process. Appendix [Table E-11](#) shows that earlier involvement is associated with partisan voting even on non-final passage votes, and the effect strengthens when more than half of positions are recorded before the first recorded vote.

5 Discussion

This paper has argued that shaping election rules affords organized groups another strategy for increasing their influence over policy outcomes. Under America's system of electoral federalism, state governments exercise primary authority over election rules and procedures, making state legislatures a central venue for this activity. I have shown that groups whose missions lie outside election policy recognize this opportunity, taking public positions on election legislation through testimony and lobbying. Their participation is widespread, but not indiscriminate. Groups engage where election policy is most likely to matter: in closely contested states, on legislation tied most directly to voter access, and where an established legislative presence lowers the cost of action. Legislative frustration also motivates participation, especially among groups with more limited state-level presence. When groups engage, they do so in predictable ideological terms, with liberal groups generally favoring expansive or improving reforms and conservative groups favoring restrictive or weakening ones. This engagement is associated with more partisan roll-call voting on election legislation and, when ideological disagreement among groups is stark, with a lower likelihood of election legislation becomes law.

These findings rest on data and measurement contributions that are themselves nontrivial. Until recently, scholars of state politics lacked systematic data on organized group positions across states and policy areas, leaving much of what we know about state-level group activity rooted in case studies of select states or inferred from patterns in Congress. This paper demonstrates how newly available data on lobbying and testimony can be used to study organized group activity systematically across states and over time. Interpreting those positions, however, also requires knowing what legislation proposes to do, including which parts of existing law it changes and in what direction. The scalable, human-in-the-loop

classification approach introduced here addresses that challenge, enabling a more precise understanding of what group positions on individual bills reveal about preferences within a policy area.

The findings also raise questions for future research. Most directly, they establish that out-of-portfolio participation, previously documented in Congress, is a feature of state legislative politics as well. But legislation is only one venue through which groups pursue their aims, and lobbying and testimony are only one channel within it. Litigation is an increasingly attractive avenue, whether as a party to a suit or through amicus briefs, especially amid legislative gridlock. Within election law, Hasen (2014, 2022) documents a sharp rise in litigation in the years—especially since *Bush v. Gore* (2000) and even more so since the 2020 presidential election—over even the most technical aspects of election administration. Groups also make use of public statements, grassroots mobilization, and campaigns for and against ballot measures that ask voters to change election policy directly. Finally, as the Election Transparency Initiative illustrates, groups increasingly act through coalitions that take positions on behalf of their member organizations, a form of activity that cannot be fully observed with the data I have collected and used in this paper. Future work should examine how groups select among these options, and with what relative success.

It is also worth acknowledging an alternative explanation for why groups engage in costly position-taking on election policy. While I argue, and find evidence consistent with the view, that groups act strategically to shape election rules for the instrumental purpose of improving their substantive representation, research on out-of-portfolio participation points to partisan signaling as another motive. As Fagan, McGee, and Thomas (2021) and Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz (2023) explain, groups aligned with a party coalition may be drawn into those debates and see value in demonstrating their ideological commitments across policy areas. Election policy may be especially useful for such signaling because debates over voting rules are now widely understood through partisan terms, especially in U.S. since 2020. Yet the evidence presented here underscoring that out-of-portfolio participation is conditional rather than widespread suggests that groups are not necessarily using election policy as an easy opportunity for signaling partisan loyalty.

If groups engage with election policy to shape outcomes rather than merely to signal,

the natural question is whether those efforts succeed. Recent work suggests that individual changes to election law often have modest and uncertain effects on who wins. Grimmer and Hersh (2024) show that most contemporary reforms target narrow, partisan-balanced slices of the electorate and move outcomes only in the closest elections, while Stephanopoulos (2025) argues that a transforming electorate has scrambled the old partisan logic, so that expansions no longer reliably favor Democrats nor restrictions Republicans. In one sense, the groups in my data behave as if they grasp this, concentrating where elections are closest and a marginal change is most likely to prove decisive. Whether sustained engagement with election policy actually delivers the representational and policy gains groups seek remains an open question, and one future work should trace directly.

Finally, groups that take up election policy face downstream risks. Taking public positions on how elections should be run can be costly in ways that go beyond the resources required to testify or lobby, exposing groups to reputational damage and, as these debates have grown more heated, political retaliation. Georgia shows how these risks can shift with the political climate. In 2021, following the January 6th attack on the U.S. Capitol and the racial-justice protests of the previous summer, voting and civil rights groups pressed the state's largest corporations to oppose SB 202, a law that tightened mail-ballot identification, limited drop boxes, and expanded legislative control over election administration.²⁸ In response, Delta and Coca-Cola—two of the state's largest corporations—criticized the law. Yet Republican officials cast the companies as partisan actors and threatened retaliation (Timm 2021). By 2026, as Georgia advanced a mid-decade redistricting plan favorable to Republicans, the same appeals fell flat and the same corporations stayed silent, wary of backlash from state policymakers (Hallerman, Hansen, and Wenk 2026). Corporations are a unique example within the set of organized groups my analysis covers as they are unusually open to economic retaliation from both activists and policymakers. Nevertheless, the point to underscore is that even if an organized group feels compelled to take action on election policy—regardless of their motivation—context greatly shapes the extent to which they feel free to do so.

That debates over election rules can provoke retaliation leads to the larger implications of this work. As Przeworski (1991, pg. 10) writes, "Democracy is a system in which parties

28. See Georgia SB 202 (2021).

lose elections," and losers accept defeat because it is temporary, with the rules of the game leaving open the chance of winning next time. The concern raised in broader discussions of democratic backsliding is that political actors may reshape election rules to make their advantage durable, bundling and sequencing changes with other tools until election outcomes become harder to reverse (Campbell and Karch 2026). The consequences reach beyond who wins any given contest. Improving election administration often requires practical cooperation and some willingness to treat administrative problems as shared problems (Hale and Brown 2020). When groups recast solutions to those problems in zero-sum terms, where one side wins and the other loses, the cooperation needed to bring innovation into election administration and improve its performance becomes harder to sustain. Even more fundamentally, public trust in elections depends not just on how well they are run, but on how political actors describe and contest them (Kerr, King, and Wahman 2024). By extending partisan and ideological conflict into how elections are conducted, organized groups risk eroding the public trust that gives elections their legitimacy and secures broad acceptance of their outcomes.

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Online Appendix for "Contesting the Rules of the Game: Organized Groups in Election Policymaking"

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A Identifying Election Legislation

To identify election legislation proposed and considered by state legislatures during this time, I rely on election legislation trackers maintained by the National Conference of State Legislatures (NCSL) and Voting Rights Lab (VRL). Legislation introduced between 2001 and 2010 are identified by a legislative log provided by NCSL staff. Legislation introduced between 2011 through 2024 are collected from the NCSL's "[State Elections Legislation Archived Database](#)" and the VRL's "[State Voting Rights Tracker](#)." Any legislation included in this study that was introduced prior to 2001 was identified using legislative journals produced by state legislatures. For this study, legislation introduced prior to 2001 was identified for the following states: California, Texas, and Washington. Research assistants were instructed to log any legislation under topic headers related to "Elections and Electors," "Elections Code," "Election Administration," and "Election Law."

Along with key info about the legislative history of introduced legislation (namely, the date of introduction and document number), each tracker provides a categorization system for the policies impacted by each bill. Throughout this study, the labels used in the categorization systems used by these trackers are collapsed into the seven categories listed below. Legislation identified by research assistants using legislative journals were manually coded as pertaining to one or more of these categories.

- *Absentee Voting/Vote-by-mail*: application process; distribution procedures; return rules and procedures; eligibility; rules concerning military/overseas voters; MOVE Act; no excuse absentee voting; permanent status; mail voting
- *Administration*: cost/funding elections; emergencies/disasters; campaign activities of election officials; general oversight of election officials; responsibilities of local election officials; responsibilities of state election officials; poll worker compensation; poll worker qualifications; poll worker training; regulation of centralized voting lists; regulation of voter list maintenance
- *Election Integrity*: post-election audit procedures; election contests (court challenges); election crimes; cybersecurity; collection/retention procedures for election data; DRE use; recount protocols; selection and standards of voting equipment/technology; ballot counting procedures; voting system testing/security/storage; policies for challenging voter eligibility; voter assistance rules
- *Logistics*: ballot design; Election Day as a holiday; dates/timing of elections; disability access; electioneering; internet voting; locations; polling place arrangement/procedures; polling place disability access; polling place locations; vote centers; polling place operating hours; poll watchers; early in-person availability; provisional voting availability; voter education/information
- *Voter Identification*: requirements/requests in place; types of identification accepted; alternatives to identification allowed; proof-of-citizenship requirements for voting
- *Voter Registration*: application form/content; automatic voter registration (AVR); dates/deadline; election-/same-day registration; electronic; general requirements; miscellaneous provisions; availability of registration drives; preregistration; ID requirement; proof-of-citizenship requirements for registration; rights for former felons and voting from jail

- *Campaigns and Parties*: candidate ballot access, filing, qualification, and withdrawal procedures; Electoral College; dual-party/fusion voting; political party organizational rules; primary election dates, rules, and procedures; runoff election procedures

B Legislative Record Collection

As listed in Appendix Section A, election legislation is identified either using legislative trackers provided by the National Conference of State Legislatures (NCSL) and the Voting Rights Lab (VRL) or using legislative journals published by state legislatures. From each source, the document number and the date of introduction and/or prefiling is recorded.

For legislation introduced between 2009 and 2024, I use the document number and introduction date to identify the corresponding legislation in the records compiled by LegiScan. Using the matched LegiScan bill records, I retrieve sponsorship, bill history, and roll-call data. I code a bill as enacted when its final recorded action indicates enactment (e.g., "chaptered," "enacted," "signed by governor"), and I identify floor roll-call votes corresponding to final passage based on vote-title keywords (e.g., "final passage," "third reading," "final vote"). For legislation introduced prior to 2009 or that was not located in the records compiled by LegiScan, I relied on the replication data provided by Bucchianeri, Volden, and Wiseman (2024) (SLES). These data provide records on sponsorship and enactment only. I match records using bill number and introduction/prefiling date. Records for remaining legislation not available through LegiScan or SLES were collected by scraping legislative information sites maintained by individual state legislatures. Because not all states provide records that can be accessed through automated scraping, this approach was limited to Arizona, California, Nevada, Texas, and Washington. For these states, complete legislative records including sponsorship, enactment, and roll-call voting are available for all years in which group position data are collected. In the remaining states where group position data begin prior to 2009, only sponsorship and enactment records are available.

C Evaluating the Effect of Election Legislation

C.1 Legislative Text Collection and Summarization

All text for legislation included in this study was obtained from one of three sources. For legislation introduced between 2015 and 2024, text was retrieved as .html files from the links made available by the National Conference of State Legislatures (NCSL) "[State Elections Legislation Archived Database](#)." These links provide legislative text collected by Lexis Nexis State Net.¹ For legislation introduced between 2009 and 2014 for which a LegiScan record ID was available, text was retrieved from .XML files provided by BillTrack50.² All remaining text was collected using web scrapers written for each state legislative information site.³

As explained by the NCSL, states different types of markup to indicate how legislation amends existing policies.⁴ After legislative text was retrieved from the above sources, the goal was to save text in a .txt file with a standardized text markup, such that:

- All text that is inserted into existing policy is wrapped in `<u class="amendmentInsertedText">` and `</u>`.

1. An example can be found here: [Alabama SB 27 \(2024\)](#).

2. See <https://www.billtrack50.com/info/>.

3. These scrapers are available here: <https://github.com/jloffredo2/state-elect-leg-scrapers>.

4. See the NCSL's [Types of Markup Used in Bills](#) guide.

- All text that is deleted from existing policy is wrapped in `<strike class="amendmentDeletedText">` and `</strike>`.

For legislation in which text was saved as .html or .XML files, simple string replacements in an R script were used to remove erroneous formatting and translate indications of insertions and deletions into the standardized format. For legislation in which text was saved as .pdf files, I relied on the optical character recognition capabilities of multimodal large language models (Greif, Griesshaber, and Greif 2025). Depending on their relative success in a handful of test cases, I either used Google's gemini-2.5-flash-preview-04-17 or Anthropic's claude-3-7-sonnet-20250219. Regardless of the model used, the prompt provided to the model was tailored to the specific markup type used by the state legislature and instructed to convert that markup language into the standardized formatting for denoting insertion and deletions across states. For example, the following prompt was used for legislation introduced in Kansas:

IMPORTANT: Output ONLY the text of the uploaded bill with the specified markup. DO NOT summarize, analyze, or add any commentary.
The uploaded PDF is a legislative bill. Your task is to process it as follows:

1. Identify any text that is italicized (indicating insertion) and wrap it with: `<u class="amendmentInsertedText">` and `</u>`
2. Identify any text with strikethrough (indicating deletion) and wrap it with: `<strike class="amendmentDeletedText">` and `</strike>`
3. Remove any line numbers appearing in the original document.
4. Output the complete bill text with these markup tags in place.

If the bill contains no underlined or strikethrough text, simply output the plain text of the bill without any markup.
For substantial insertions or deletions that span multiple lines or paragraphs, identify the beginning and end of the entire amended block. Wrap the whole block with a single set of `<u class="amendmentInsertedText">` and `</u>` tags (for insertions) or `<strike class="amendmentDeletedText">` and `</strike>` tags (for deletions).
Do not tag each line individually if they are part of the same continuous inserted or deleted section.
Your response must contain ONLY the processed bill text - no introduction, explanation, or commentary of any kind.

Using the plain text files created following this process, Anthropic's claude-sonnet-4-20250514 model was then used to create a summary for each piece of legislation. The prompt provided to the model is provided below and is written intentionally to encourage the model to write concise, human-like quality summaries that focus primarily on the specific changes a piece of legislation makes to existing election law.

You will be provided a text file that contains the text of state election legislation. Your task is to WRITE a summary of the legislation. Your summary should be specific to detail all the ways how the legislation changes existing policy in the given state.

INSTRUCTIONS: No proper grammar is needed. Write ONLY the summary content. Do NOT include any extra comments, explanations, or introduction in your response. This is especially the case if you are presented with only a section of the full text of a bill. For example, do not start with "This legislation...", say "Here are the key changes:", or use markdown formatting. Just write the summary content directly. Begin your response with an action verb.

Use the HTML format to help you identify language this is inserted into existing policy. Inserted language will be wrapped in `<u class="amendmentInsertedText">` and `</u>`. Further, you should also use the HTML format to help you identify language that is removed from existing policy. Removed language will be wrapped in `<strike class="amendmentDeletedText">` and `</strike>`.

If the bill contains an abstract, summary, or digest, you may use that to help you summarize the bill.

Here are a few examples of how the summaries should be written:

1. "Allow county board of elections to meet up to 10 days before election day to pre-canvass all absentee and mail ballots recieved before the Friday before election day"
2. "Establish same-day registration; establish early in-person voting"
3. "Allow counties to establish satellite election offices; allow registered voters to submit absentee ballots in person on election day in satellite election offices"

C.2 Rating Schema

Each bill is assigned one of four labels describing its overall effect on voter access and the quality of election administration: *Expansive/Improves*, *Restrictive/Worsens*, *Mixed/Unclear*, or *Neutral*. Classification is based on a close reading of legislative text, with attention to provisions that insert, amend, or remove language in existing election law. This schema mimics, but varies slightly from those used by James and Stewart (2022) and the Voting Rights Lab. These labels are defined as:

- *Expansive/Improves*: Lowers barriers to participation or improves the capacity, professionalism, or quality of election administration.
- *Restrictive/Worsens*: Raises barriers to participation or diminishes the capacity, professionalism, or quality of election administration.
- *Mixed/Unclear*: Combines offsetting effects across policy areas or consists primarily of narrow technical changes with ambiguous implications.
- *Neutral*: Does not substantively affect the election policy areas examined in this study.

Below are illustrative (not exhaustive) examples of how provisions are classified within each policy area.

- **Absentee Voting and Vote-by-Mail**
 - *Expansive/Improves*: Expanding eligibility (e.g., no-excuse absentee voting, universal mail voting, permanent absentee status); automatically sending ballots or applications; extending request or return deadlines; allowing ballot curing or relaxed signature verification; expanding electronic absentee voting; broadening ballot assistance; increasing ballot drop boxes; implementing ballot tracking systems; improving access for military and overseas voters.
 - *Restrictive/Worsens*: Restricting eligibility; shortening request or return deadlines; limiting automatic distribution of ballots or applications; tightening rules on ballot assistance or curing; imposing stricter signature matching requirements; reducing ballot drop box availability.

- **Election Administration**

- *Expansive/Improves*: Increasing election funding; shifting costs to the state; granting discretion during emergencies; restricting campaign activity by election officials; strengthening oversight and accountability; clarifying official responsibilities; increasing poll worker pay, benefits, or training; improving voter list maintenance; authorizing or requiring participation in ERIC; implementing or expanding state voting rights acts.
- *Restrictive/Worsens*: Cutting election funding; prohibiting private election funding; shifting costs to local jurisdictions; limiting emergency discretion; weakening oversight; granting broad authority without clear standards; reducing poll worker compensation or training; limiting voter list maintenance tools; lowering thresholds for voter removal; prohibiting participation in ERIC.

- **Election Integrity**

- *Expansive/Improves*: Establishing standards for post-election audits and recounts; clarifying procedures for election challenges and litigation; increasing penalties for threats or interference; reducing penalties for minor voter errors; strengthening cybersecurity; standardizing ballot counting; setting clear standards for voting equipment testing, certification, and data retention.
- *Restrictive/Worsens*: Eliminating audit or recount requirements; delegating authority to courts without guidance; weakening penalties for election interference; increasing penalties for minor voter errors; mandating DRE voting machines; devolving voting system oversight to local jurisdictions with minimal state guidance.

- **Logistics of Voting Procedures**

- *Expansive/Improves*: Improving ballot design; making Election Day a holiday; expanding polling place hours or locations; increasing vote centers or early voting; expanding provisional voting; improving disability access; expanding internet voting; strengthening protections against electioneering and intimidation; enhancing voter education and notification; improving language accommodations; permitting voter assistance; clarifying poll watcher rules.
- *Restrictive/Worsens*: Reducing polling place hours, locations, vote centers, or early voting; restricting provisional voting; banning voter assistance; prohibiting provision of food or water to voters waiting in line.

- **Voter Identification**

- *Expansive/Improves*: Eliminating photo ID requirements; expanding acceptable forms of identification; removing proof-of-citizenship requirements.
- *Restrictive/Worsens*: Imposing photo ID requirements; narrowing acceptable identification types; requiring proof of citizenship to vote.

- **Voter Registration**

- *Expansive/Improves*: Implementing automatic, same-day, preregistration, or online registration; extending registration deadlines; expanding agency-based registration; supporting registration drives; facilitating registration for incarcerated individuals or parolees.

- *Restrictive/Worsens*: Eliminating automatic, same-day, preregistration, or online registration; shortening registration deadlines; tightening active-status requirements; restricting registration drives; prohibiting registration for incarcerated individuals; requiring proof of citizenship to register.

C.3 Automated Rating Methodology

Approach To automate the assignment of *Expansive/Improves*, *Restrictive/Worsens*, *Mixed/Unclear*, and *Neutral* labels for each bill, I pass summaries of each piece of legislation to one of two models. The goal is to produce labels from two separate models. For legislation in which the two models are not in agreement, a research assistant manually assigns a label. For legislation in which the two models are in agreement, labels from the best-performing model during testing are used. This mimics the guidance of Heseltine and Von Hohenberg (2024) that users may see improved performance in annotation tasks when using a "hybrid approach" in which multiple runs of a classification model is combined with human intervention.

In this study, I implement (1) a multi-output support vector machine (SVM) classifier and (2) a fine-tuned large language model (LLM). The relative success of LLMs in annotating political text (Gilardi, Alizadeh, and Kubli 2023; Halterman and Keith 2024; Heseltine and Von Hohenberg 2024) motivated the use of an LLM for the task of classifying election legislation. However, given concerns about the threat of hallucinations from LLMs (Ji et al. 2023), I complement using an LLM with a traditional machine learning approach for text classification.

Prior to implementing these models, a team of research assistants read the full text of 20% of election legislation introduced since 2009.⁵ A 60/20/20 split was used to create training, testing, and validation datasets.

Before deciding which traditional machine learning approach and which LLM would be used for this task, I trained a range of different approaches using the training dataset and calculated their performance using the testing datasets. Both an overall rating and six policy-area ratings are created for each piece of legislation. In [Table C-1](#), I present performance metrics for the overall ratings; [Table C-2](#) presents performance metrics for each model averaged across the six policy-area ratings. Traditional ML approaches labeled with `multioutput_` are multi-output models that fit one classifier of the indicated type per target (six policy areas plus overall rating); those labeled with `2stage_` implement a two-stage hierarchical approach where policy area predictions are augmented into the feature space to train a downstream bill rating classifier. Among commercial LLMs, only OpenAI's GPT models allow for fine tuning. Thus, I test performance across a range of commercial LLMs plus a fine-tuned GPT model (`gpt-4.1-mini-2025-04-14`).

Overall, my goal is to balance performance for bill ratings with policy area ratings. As indicated in [Table C-1](#), the multi-output support vector SVM classifier and the fine-tuned GPT model performance best when using the *F*-score as the evaluation metric. For policy area ratings, the fine-tuned GPT model again shows the best performance, however, the multi-output SVM classifier is not the best among traditional ML models. Nevertheless, given that its performance is comparable to the random forest models, I opt for using multi-output SVM classifier given its performance for assigning overall ratings.

5. This text was collected prior to writing web scrapers that collected text for legislation introduced before 2009. Thus, this manually classified set includes text collected from Lexis Nexis State Net and BillTrack50 only.

Table C-1: Bill Rating Classification Metrics (Testing)

Approach	Model	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F Score
Traditional ML	multioutput_svm	0.729	0.766	0.626	0.689
Traditional ML	multioutput_logistic	0.703	0.640	0.681	0.660
Traditional ML	2stage_svm	0.677	0.666	0.650	0.657
Traditional ML	2stage_random_forest	0.683	0.677	0.630	0.652
Traditional ML	multioutput_random_forest	0.672	0.668	0.614	0.640
Traditional ML	2stage_logistic	0.666	0.583	0.663	0.621
Traditional ML	multioutput_gradient_boosting	0.709	0.705	0.552	0.619
Traditional ML	2stage_gradient_boosting	0.617	0.570	0.601	0.585
LLM	ft_gpt-4.1-mini-2025-04-14_personal_election-leg_BumQ03pZ	0.760	0.718	0.727	0.723
LLM	claude-3-7-sonnet-20250219	0.650	0.598	0.606	0.602
LLM	claude-3-5-haiku-20241022	0.652	0.551	0.618	0.583
LLM	gpt-4.1-mini-2025-04-14	0.599	0.507	0.632	0.563
LLM	gemini-2.5-flash-lite-preview-06-17	0.598	0.516	0.591	0.551
LLM	gpt-4o-mini-2024-07-18	0.573	0.487	0.623	0.547
LLM	gemini-2.5-flash	0.606	0.524	0.539	0.531
LLM	o4-mini-2025-04-16	0.470	0.789	0.264	0.395

Table C-2: Policy Rating Classification Metrics (Testing)

Approach	Model	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F Score
Traditional ML	2stage_random_forest	0.704	0.626	0.683	0.615
Traditional ML	multioutput_random_forest	0.704	0.626	0.683	0.615
Traditional ML	2stage_svm	0.728	0.698	0.504	0.577
Traditional ML	multioutput_svm	0.728	0.698	0.504	0.577
Traditional ML	2stage_gradient_boosting	0.869	0.630	0.508	0.561
Traditional ML	multioutput_gradient_boosting	0.869	0.630	0.508	0.561
Traditional ML	2stage_logistic	0.628	0.518	0.643	0.547
Traditional ML	multioutput_logistic	0.628	0.518	0.643	0.547
LLM	ft_gpt-4.1-mini-2025-04-14_personal_election-leg_BumQ03pZ	0.885	0.663	0.621	0.640
LLM	claude-3-7-sonnet-20250219	0.751	0.500	0.619	0.553
LLM	o4-mini-2025-04-16	0.683	0.551	0.557	0.536
LLM	gpt-4o-mini-2024-07-18	0.779	0.473	0.588	0.523
LLM	gemini-2.5-flash-lite-preview-06-17	0.734	0.480	0.575	0.523
LLM	gemini-2.5-flash	0.721	0.470	0.578	0.518
LLM	claude-3-5-haiku-20241022	0.535	0.630	0.484	0.489
LLM	gpt-4.1-mini-2025-04-14	0.528	0.447	0.442	0.425

Details for fine-tuning gpt-4.1-mini-2025-04-14 are presented below:

- **Training method:** supervised
- **Base model:** gpt-4.1-mini-2025-04-14
- **Trained tokens:** 5,883,810
- **Hyperparameters:**
 - Epochs: 3
 - Batch size: 2
 - LR multiplier: 2
 - Seed: 125

The multi-output SVM classifier was trained using the training dataset. The fine-tuned model is trained on a 25% sample of the training dataset (due to file size limitations for batch uploads) and fine-tuning was validated using the test dataset. I provided the following prompt for fine-tuning and for using the fine-tuned model to assign labels for legislation:

You are tasked with analyzing election administration legislation and providing classifications of its impact on voter access and election administration quality. For each bill, you must provide an overall rating and individual ratings for six policy areas.

Classification Categories

Use these four categories for all ratings:

- Expansive/Improves: Makes it easier and more accessible for voters to cast a ballot OR improves the quality and professionalization of election administration
- Restrictive/Worsens: Makes it harder and less accessible for voters to cast a ballot OR worsens the quality and professionalization of election administration
- Mixed/Unclear: Contains provisions that affect voter access and election administration quality in different ways across policy areas, OR contains mostly small, technical wording changes
- Neutral: Has no relevance to voter access or election administration quality (e.g., provisions about healthcare, taxation, campaign finance, administrative procedures unrelated to elections)

Policy Areas to Analyze

Evaluate each bill's impact on these six policy areas:

1. Absentee Voting/Vote-by-Mail (abvbm)

Expansive/Improves examples:

- Expands eligibility (e.g., no-excuse, universal vote-by-mail)
- Automatically sends mail ballots or applications to eligible voters
- Extends deadlines to request/return absentee/mail ballots
- Allows or expands ballot curing or voter assistance for mail/absentee voting
- Expands electronic voting options or number of dropboxes/drop-off locations
- Implements ballot tracking systems

Restrictive/Worsens examples:

- Limits eligibility (e.g., age, disability)
- Shortens application or submission deadlines
- Restricts automatic sending of ballots/applications
- Imposes signature matching requirements
- Prohibits or limits voter assistance for mail or absentee voting
- Limits ballot curing processes
- Reduces number of ballot dropboxes/drop-off locations

2. Election Administration (admin)

Expansive/Improves examples:

- Strengthens institutional capacity or professional standards
- Provides additional financial resources for elections
- Requires state (vs. local) funding of elections
- Expands emergency powers
- Restricts officials from political activities
- Increases oversight and accountability mechanisms
- Improves poll worker pay, training, and resources
- Provides additional staffing and professional development
- Increases penalties for threatening officials
- Provides standards and tools for voter list maintenance
- Authorizes ERIC participation

Restrictive/Worsens examples:

- Reduces institutional capacity or weakens professional standards

- Delegates authority over election officials without guidance
- Cuts or limits funding
- Places funding burden on local jurisdictions
- Restricts emergency accommodations
- Reduces oversight or poll worker compensation/training
- Weakens penalties for threatening officials
- Limits voter roll maintenance tools
- Lowers thresholds for voter removal
- Prohibits ERIC participation

3. Election Integrity (integrity)

Expansive/Improves examples:

- Sets standards for audits, recounts, and election challenges
- Lowers penalties for minor, unintentional infractions
- Improves voting technology security and testing standards
- Requires use of modern, auditable voting systems (e.g., paper ballots, optical scan)
- Phases out outdated voting technology
- Establishes procedures for data collection/retention

Restrictive/Worsens examples:

- Removes audit or recount requirements
- Increases penalties for minor infractions
- Mandates DRE voting machines or outdated technology
- Reduces security standards
- Leaves local jurisdictions without state oversight for technology

4. Logistics of Voting Procedures (logistics)

Expansive/Improves examples:

- Expands polling hours, locations, or early/advanced voting days
- Improves accessibility (ballot design, disability access, language)
- Makes Election Day a state holiday
- Expands eligibility for in-person absentee or early voting
- Expands provisional ballot use
- Strengthens anti-electioneering rules
- Improves voter education and notification
- Allows poll watchers without disruption
- Allows or expands voter assistance

Restrictive/Worsens examples:

- Decreases polling hours, locations, or early voting
- Restricts in-person absentee or early voting eligibility
- Bans providing food/water to voters in line
- Restricts provisional ballot use or voter assistance
- Limits language or disability accommodations

5. Voter Identification (voterid)

Expansive/Improves examples:

- Removes photo ID requirements
- Adds acceptable forms of identification
- Removes proof of citizenship requirements

Restrictive/Worsens examples:

- Implements photo ID requirements
- Reduces acceptable ID types
- Requires proof of citizenship

6. Voter Registration (vtrreg)

Expansive/Improves examples:

- Implements or expands automatic (AVR), same-day, pre-, or online registration
- Extends registration deadlines
- Expands role of motor vehicle (DMV) and government agencies
- Provides resources for registration drives
- Allows incarcerated individuals/parolees to register

- Uses inclusive voter eligibility language

Restrictive/Worsens examples:

- Eliminates AVR, same-day registration, pre-registration
- Pushes back registration deadlines
- Increases standards for maintaining active status
- Restricts registration drives
- Limits outreach or third-party registration
- Prevents incarcerated individuals from registering
- Adopts exclusionary eligibility language

Output Format

Provide analysis in JSON format:

```
{
  "UUID": "[provided UUID]",
  "version_number": "[provided version_number]",
  "bill_rating": "[Expansive/Improves | Restrictive/Worsens | Mixed/Unclear |
Neutral]",
  "abvbm": "[Expansive/Improves | Restrictive/Worsens | Mixed/Unclear | Neutral]",
  "admin": "[Expansive/Improves | Restrictive/Worsens | Mixed/Unclear | Neutral]",
  "integrity": "[Expansive/Improves | Restrictive/Worsens | Mixed/Unclear |
Neutral]",
  "logistics": "[Expansive/Improves | Restrictive/Worsens | Mixed/Unclear |
Neutral]",
  "voterid": "[Expansive/Improves | Restrictive/Worsens | Mixed/Unclear | Neutral]",
  "vtrreg": "[Expansive/Improves | Restrictive/Worsens | Mixed/Unclear | Neutral]"
}
```

Important Guidelines

1. Be comprehensive: Consider all provisions in the bill
2. Distinguish between policy areas
3. Consider practical impact on voters and election administration
4. Classification logic: If provision doesn't clearly fit examples but has obvious impact, classify based on whether it makes voting easier/harder or improves/worsens administration quality. Use Mixed/Unclear for provisions with ambiguous impact. Use Neutral only for provisions completely unrelated to elections.
5. Output only JSON: Return only the JSON object, no additional text, explanation, or justification
6. Terminology clarification: "In-person absentee voting," "advance voting," and "early voting" refer to the same concept. "Provisional ballot" might also be called "affidavit ballot."

After both models assigned ratings, approximately 32.5% of all election legislation required manual evaluation. Research assistants read summaries for each piece of legislation and assigned labels for an overall rating and the six policy-area ratings.

Performance Metrics Using the validation dataset, the final performance metrics for classification are:

Table C-3: Final Rating Classification Metrics

Label	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F Score
Overall Rating	0.865	0.855	0.841	0.848
Absentee Voting/Vote-by-mail	0.932	0.844	0.801	0.822
Administration	0.851	0.771	0.679	0.722
Election Integrity	0.908	0.797	0.658	0.721
Logistics	0.880	0.829	0.771	0.799
Voter Identification	0.979	0.890	0.771	0.826
Voter Registration	0.945	0.874	0.841	0.857

D Group Position Data Collection

D.1 Sources and Record Linkage

To identify the positions (support, oppose, neutral/monitoring) groups take on legislation, I rely on (1) the Dataset on Policy Choice and Organizational Representation in the United States (CHORUS) (Hall et al. 2024) and (2) committee records available in state legislative information sites. CHORUS records cover the following states: Arizona, Colorado, Florida, Iowa, Illinois, Kansas, Massachusetts, Maryland, Missouri, Montana, Nebraska, New Jersey, Ohio, Rhode Island, South Dakota, Texas, and Wisconsin. Records that I collected from state legislative information sites cover the following states: California, Nevada, Oregon, Utah, and Washington.

CHORUS covers both lobbying position disclosures as well as positions collected from public testimony, committee meeting minutes, or "witness lists." Records from California and Washington are collected from bill analyses written by committee staff. These analyses contain background information, fiscal and legal implications, suggestions for improvement, and listings of entities that support and oppose along with their rationale.⁶ Records from Oregon are parsed from letters of public testimony submitted by the public.⁷ I use an LLM to help extract any organization affiliation associated with the individual submitting the letter of public testimony. Records from Nevada and Utah are collected from committee hearing minutes.⁸

Records from CHORUS are primarily linked to election-related legislation (as described in Appendix Section A) using LegiScan record identifiers. Any remaining records are matched using a combination of document number and legislative session identifiers.

Across all analyses, I retain only the most recent position taken by each group on a given piece of legislation. For CHORUS records, this is determined using the `start_date` and `end_date` fields; for records collected directly from state legislative information sites, recency is determined by the date associated with the relevant testimony, submission, or committee report. This approach is intended to capture groups' positions as legislation approaches final consideration.

6. Examples of bill analyses: [California AB 626 \(2023-2024\)](#), [Washington HB 1443 \(2023-2024\)](#).

7. Examples of public testimony submitted for [Oregon SB 1577 \(2024\)](#).

8. Examples of committee hearing minutes: [Nevada SB 404 \(2023\)](#) and [Utah HB 37 \(2023\)](#).

Table D-4: Sample Summary

Variable	All States N = 50	Sample States N = 22
% Years Democrat Trifecta	22.1 (22.3)	23.6 (24.6)
% Years Republican Trifecta	36.0 (33.2)	38.9 (36.9)
% Years Divided	41.9 (21.8)	37.4 (22.0)
Gov. Vote Margin	0.162 (0.071)	0.153 (0.071)
POTUS Vote Margin	0.150 (0.082)	0.139 (0.082)
Legislative Professionalism	0.228 (0.140)	0.256 (0.135)

¹ Mean (SD)

Note: Summary statistics averaged over all years included in the study (1995–2024).

Appendix Table D-4 reports summary statistics comparing the states in my sample to all states over the full study period (1995–2024). I compare average gubernatorial and presidential vote margins; the share of years spent under Democratic, Republican, and divided government; and legislative professionalism as measured by Squire (1992, 2024). The sample states are broadly representative of the nation as a whole across these dimensions.

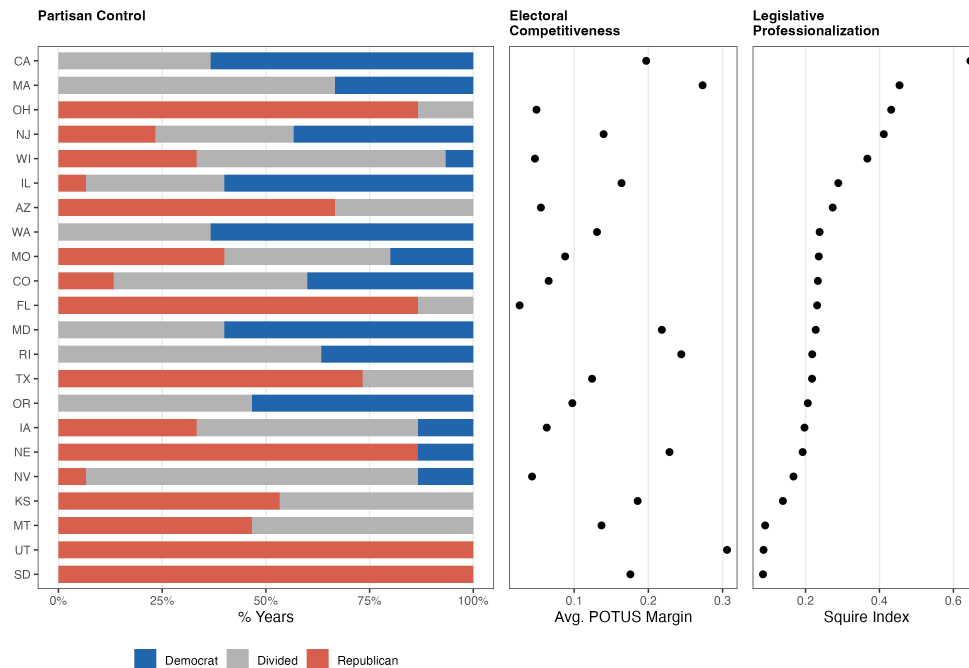


Figure D-1: Summary of Variation in Key Political and Legislative Variables in Sample

Appendix Figure D-1 shows variation across the 22 sample states along partisan control, electoral competitiveness, and legislative professionalization. The first panel shows substantial heterogeneity in partisan control, with some states spending the majority of observed years under unified Democratic or Republican government and others spending most years under

divided government. The second and third panels show similarly wide variation in average presidential vote margins and legislative professionalization scores, confirming that the sample is not dominated by any single type of state political environment.

D.2 Wisconsin Lobbying Effort Records

Wisconsin requires registered lobbying organizations to report, in semi-annual filings, the number of hours their lobbyists devote to each specific legislative proposal on which the organization is registered. These filings are submitted to the Wisconsin Ethics Commission and are publicly accessible through the state's lobbying disclosure portal at <https://lobbying.wi.gov>. I scrape these records for all sessions from 2009 through 2024, covering eight legislative biennia. Each record links a registered principal (the lobbying organization) to a specific bill and a reporting period, and records the number of lobbyist hours devoted to that bill during the period. Reporting periods correspond to the first half (*H1*: January–June) and second half (*H2*: July–December) of each calendar year. In addition to hours, the disclosure system records the position taken by each principal on each bill—coded as *For*, *Against*, or *In favor of if amended*—which I treat as equivalent to support, opposition, and neutral stances, respectively.

For each principal, I sum hours across both halves of each calendar year and then aggregate across the two calendar years comprising a legislative biennium. This yields a single hours figure per principal per bill per biennium. Where a group registers a position on a bill without reporting any lobbyist hours, I retain the position record but treat the hours as zero; this is consistent with the disclosure system allowing organizations to register a stance without devoting paid staff time to the legislation.

Principal names in the Wisconsin disclosure system are harmonized with the broader group-identity framework described in Appendix Section D.3. Wisconsin principal names are run through the same text-normalization and deduplication pipeline, and each principal is assigned the canonical group identifier used across all states. This linkage allows Wisconsin lobbying effort data to be merged with group-level metadata—including organizational type, primary policy area, and ideal point estimates—and with position records from CHORUS for the same state and period. Groups that appear in CHORUS for Wisconsin but for which no effort records exist are retained in the broader analysis sample; the Wisconsin effort records are used only for analyses that explicitly require lobbying hour data.

D.3 Group Disambiguation & Metadata

CHORUS resolves organization identities by collapsing name variants and duplicate records through matches to external reference databases such as FollowTheMoney and OpenSecrets, assigning a unique identifier to each entity. I build on this work by undertaking additional steps to harmonize organization names across datasets, allowing groups to be consistently identified in the five additional states for which I collect position data and enabling federated organizations operating across multiple states (e.g., state chapters of the ACLU) to be treated as a single organization. For this, I perform the following steps:

1. **Compile list of group names across sources:** I create a master list of all organization names appearing in CHORUS and in the group-position records collected from additional states, retaining source-specific identifiers (e.g., state-level client IDs) and state labels.
2. **Remove non-organizational entries:** I exclude records that clearly correspond to individuals or self-references (e.g., "self," "myself," "representing myself").

3. **Apply rule-based text normalization:** I standardize names using a consistent set of string-cleaning rules: lowercasing, removing punctuation and parenthetical text, stripping boilerplate (e.g., "representing," "on behalf of"), eliminating address-like fragments, and expanding common abbreviations and acronyms (e.g., "assn" → "association," "lww" → "league of women voters").
4. **Detect government entities:** I use keyword rules to identify group names that correspond to state or local government agencies and standardize their naming in a format that attaches their state and standardizes common offices (e.g., Secretary of State, Attorney General, Governor's Office) and local units (e.g., counties and cities).
5. **Initial deduplication via string similarity:** After basic name cleaning, I conduct a first-pass deduplication that clusters near-duplicate organization names using n -gram Jaccard similarity. This step is implemented using the `jaccard_string_group()` function from the `zoomerjoin` package. This step captures common spelling variants, abbreviations, and minor formatting differences in organization names.
6. **Name standardization for common national organizations:** To ensure consistent handling of widely observed federated or acronym-heavy organizations (e.g., ACLU, SEIU, NAACP, League of Women Voters, Planned Parenthood), I use keywords to map common naming variants to a single name used across states.
7. **Filter remaining non-organizations.** I remove remaining entries appearing to be individuals, addresses, or role titles rather than organizations using keyword detection.
8. **Use an LLM for remaining names:** For remaining group names that have yet to be standardize, I submit the state and name of the group to `gpt-5-mini`. The model is instructed to standardize the group names based on specific rules, including:
 - (a) Merge chapters/affiliates into national organizations where appropriate. If state-specific, include state (e.g., "South Dakota Automobile Dealers Association").
 - (b) Government/public organizations: state label should be kept (e.g., "Texas Secretary of State") near-duplicates should be merged (Dept of State TX → Texas Secretary of State).
 - (c) Government/public officials: map officials to their office (e.g., "Governor Jane Doe" → "Office of the Governor of [State]", "Alex Padilla, Secretary of State" → "[State] Secretary of State")
 - (d) Individuals/self ("Concerned Citizen", "Student") should map to "Individual". However, if there are individuals like "county of humboldt supervisor rex bohn district", map to their office (e.g., "Humboldt County Supervisor's Office"). Groups with "Individual" as their name are removed from the dataset as per Step (2).
 - (e) Minor typos/abbreviations (e.g., "Amer. Bar Assoc." → "American Bar Association") should be fixed or expanded.
9. **Final deduplication and identity assignment:** After incorporating LLM-assisted name standardization, I perform a second pass of n -gram Jaccard similarity using the same `jaccard_string_group()` function used in Step (5). Following this, each unique standardized organization name is assigned a unique numeric identifier which is used to link all group position data used in this study.

Using these standardized names, I add two pieces of metadata. First, I label groups as being *Advocacy*, *Government*, or *Political*. *Advocacy* groups encompass a broad set of non-governmental actors, including identity- or membership-based groups, policy and issue advocacy organizations, labor unions, industry and trade associations (including private corporations), service-providing nonprofits, and multi-organization coalitions or alliances. *Government* groups include state agencies, local governments, individual public officials, and professional associations of public administrators (e.g., associations of election officials). *Political* groups include formal party organizations, candidate and campaign committees, political action committees (PACs and Super PACs), and partisan political clubs or activist chapters. The analyses in this study focus on *Advocacy* and *Political* groups only. Initial classification is performed using a rule-based approach that matches standardized group names to keyword patterns associated with each subcategory. Groups that cannot be confidently classified using these rules are subsequently coded using a large language model instructed to use the taxonomy. If a group's type cannot be reasonably inferred from its name alone, it is left uncoded.

Second, I determine the group's primary policy area. The possible values are: Agriculture & Food, Business & Commerce, Civil Rights & Constitutional Issues, Education & Schools, Elections & Voting, Energy & Utilities, Environment & Natural Resources, Fiscal & Economic Policy, Health & Public Health, Housing & Community Development, International Affairs & Immigration, Judiciary & Law Enforcement, Labor & Employment, Local & State Government, Military, Veterans, & Defense, Social Services & Welfare, Taxation, and Transportation & Infrastructure. These labels are similar to that used by Dee and Garlick (2025) which mimic those used by the Policy Agendas Project (Jones et al. 2023). I assign each group a single primary policy area label through a three-step process. First, I determine the subjects of legislation on which the organization took positions—using both a collapsed version of the subject names used by LegiScan and the labels generated by Dee and Garlick (2025)—and assign the modal subject as the organization's `top_ls_subject` (LegiScan subjects) and `top_dee_subject` (subjects produced by Dee and Garlick). Second, where available, I incorporate CHORUS-linked FollowTheMoney industry codes and recode `ftm_industry` into to match these policy area labels. Third, I assign each organization a single primary policy area label using the following rules:

- If any source classifies the organization as related to elections, it is coded as *Elections & Voting*.
- When multiple sources agree on an policy area, I assign that shared category.
- When sources disagree, I assign the policy area indicated by the first available source in a fixed order: `ftm_industry`, `top_ls_subject`, then `top_dee_subject`.
- Groups still missing a label are coded with a structured LLM prompt using these policy area labels.
- Some well-known groups are mapped to the issue are they are widely assumed to be focused in (e.g., party committees → *Elections & Voting*, ACLU → *Civil Rights & Constitutional Issues*).

D.4 Group Ideal Point Estimates

Approach To measure the ideology of groups that is on a left-right dimension and is interpretable in the same manner as other well-known ideological scores, I follow a process that borrows from the methodologies used by Shor and McCarty (2011), Thieme (2020), and Crosson, Furnas, and Lorenz (2020) (CRL). This involves estimating a Bayesian item response theory (IRT) model that jointly scales group positions on legislation with legislators' final-passage roll call votes on the same pieces of legislation. I use the `ideal()` function from the `pscl` R package to fit a one-dimensional item-response model via Markov chain Monte Carlo (MCMC). The posterior means of ideal points for legislators and groups are used as ideal point score estimates.

The IRT model is estimated using all legislation from states in which interest-group position data are available. Although election legislation analyzed in this study is included in the estimation, most of the data used to fit the model come from LegiScan and involve non-election legislation introduced between 2009 and 2024. For each bill, I retain only a group's most recent position, and I include only final passage roll-call votes by legislators. Group "support" positions are treated as equivalent to legislator yea votes, and group "oppose" positions are treated as equivalent to nay votes. I combine group positions and legislator roll-call votes into a single vote matrix in which rows represent actors, columns represent bills, and cells record each actor's position on a bill. Following CRL, I remove bills with unanimous positions and then apply a k -core filtration with $k = 4$ (Dorogovtsev, Goltsev, and Mendes 2006). This procedure yields a matrix containing only actors who took positions on at least five bills, each of which received positions from at least five actors, ensuring that ideal point estimates are identified using the dense core of the position-taking network.

To identify the IRT model and place ideal point estimates on a common left-right scale, I impose constraints on a set of legislators using their Shor-McCarty common space scores as anchoring values. For each state, I first restrict attention to legislators who served during the years in which group position data are available and who fall above the 75th percentile in the number of roll call votes cast. From this subset, I select the Democratic legislators with the minimum, median, and maximum scores and the Republican legislators with the minimum, median, and maximum scores.⁹ These constrained legislators anchor the ideological scale, ensuring that estimated ideal points are interpretable and comparable *within* each state. The ideal points of all other legislators and groups are then estimated freely relative to these anchors.

I estimate the model separately for each state. To make ideal point estimates comparable *across* states, I project state-specific ideal points onto the Shor-McCarty common space using ordinary least squares (OLS) regression. Specifically, within each state I regress legislators' Shor-McCarty common space scores on their estimated ideal points and use the fitted model to project group ideal points onto the same scale. Observations in this regression are weighted by the total number of roll call votes in which each actor participated. This procedure yields state-specific group ideal points that are directly comparable across states. Because many groups operate in multiple states, I then construct a single ideal point estimate for each group by taking a weighted average of its state-level scores, where the weights reflect the share of the group's total positions taken in each state. This approach assumes that groups possess a latent ideological position that is consistent across states. Note that this external anchoring strategy differs from Thieme (2020), who achieves cross-state comparability endogenously by including

9. In Nebraska, which has a nonpartisan unicameral legislature, I instead select the legislators with the minimum, median, and maximum scores.

groups lobbying in multiple states and PCT survey respondents as bridging observations in a single joint estimation. Given the amount of data to be included in the joint-estimation process for 22 states, the bridging approach was not possible. My approach of anchoring within-state estimates to the Shor-McCarty common space and projecting via OLS is more appropriate in my case because scales to the much larger number of states included in my study compared to Thieme (2020).

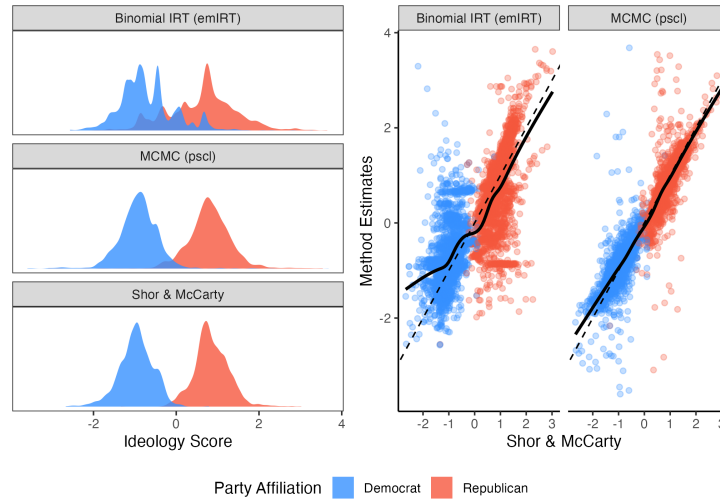
Validity To assess the validity of the group ideal point estimates, I examine their correlation with established measures of ideology on a left-right dimension. This analysis evaluates the *convergent validity* of the estimated ideal points.

As described above, my procedure produces ideal point estimates for both interest groups and legislators. In [Figure D-2a](#), I first validate the estimates for *legislators* by comparing them to their corresponding Shor-McCarty common space scores. The facets labeled "MCMC (pscl)" correspond to the estimation approach used in this study, while the facets labeled "Binomial IRT (emIRT)" show estimates produced using the `binIRT()` function from the `emIRT` package for comparison (Imai, Lo, and Olmsted 2016).¹⁰ As shown, ideal point estimates from the model fit via MCMC using the `ideal()` function from the `pscl` R package are positively correlated with Shor-McCarty scores ($\rho = 0.78$).

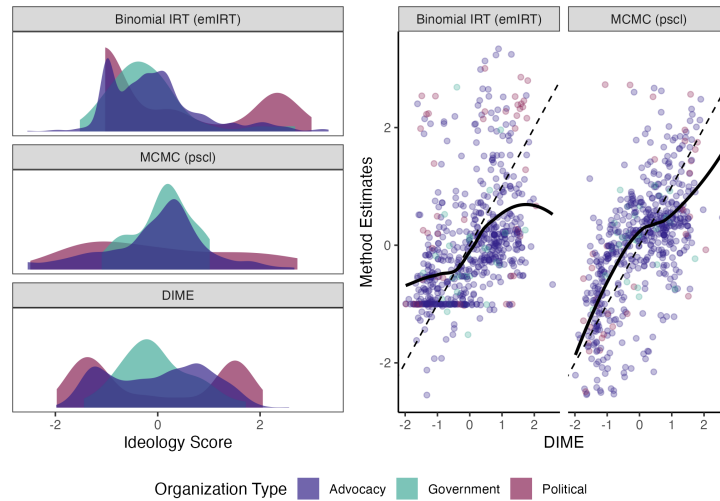
In [Figure D-2b](#), I examine group ideal point estimates in a similar fashion, using DIME CFscores (Bonica 2024) as the comparison. Again, my ideal point estimates appear positively correlated with their benchmark, though only weakly ($\rho = 0.34$). This comparison deserves a couple points for contextualization. First, among the 4,209 total group entities that took positions on election legislation, only 726 could be located in the DIME contributor database. Second, the types of behavior that is mapped to ideology in both datasets—either public, costly position taking efforts in my case or campaign donation in the case of DIME CFscores—have different implications. While lobbying activity or public testimony allows groups to publicly convey their policy positions, DIME CFscores may reflect a different mix of motivations. As Phillips (2024) argues, contribution behavior can reflect *ideological* strategies (supporting candidates who share a group's policy views) or *access-oriented* strategies (seeking influence with incumbents regardless of ideological proximity). To the extent that groups pursue access, their CFscores may appear more liberal or conservative than their public position-taking behavior would suggest. Consequently, differences between my estimates and DIME CFscores may reflect differences in group strategy, rather than divergence in estimates of their ideology.

Given the relatively weak correlation between my group ideal point estimates and DIME CFscores, I also assess validity of my estimates compared to their observed position-taking behavior on election legislation. For this, see Appendix [Table E-8](#).

10. In the binomial IRT model, the scale is anchored to the most conservative legislator who participated in at least the 75th percentile of all roll-call votes.



(a) **Legislators.** Comparison of ideal point estimates to Shor–McCarty common space scores.



(b) **Interest groups.** Comparison of ideal point estimates to DIME CFscores.

Figure D-2: **Validation of Ideal Point Estimates.** Each panel displays density plots of ideal point estimates produced using a binomial IRT model (top), an IRT model fit via MCMC (middle; the method used in this study), and the corresponding benchmark estimates (bottom). The right side of each panel plots ideal point estimates against benchmark scores. The top panel compares legislator estimates to Shor–McCarty common space scores, and the bottom panel compares group estimates to DIME CFscores. All quantities are standardized to have mean zero and standard deviation one.

E Supplemental Analyses

E.1 When Do Organized Groups Participate in Election Policy?

Table E-5: Effects of Electoral Competition on Out-of-Portfolio Group Participation

	All	Absentee/VBM	Administration	Election Integrity	Logistics	Voter ID	Voter Registration	Campaign & Party
Competition	0.174*** (0.029)	0.059*** (0.017)	0.079*** (0.017)	0.025 (0.017)	0.235*** (0.022)	-0.029* (0.012)	0.034+ (0.020)	0.180*** (0.017)
N	52707	52707	52707	52707	52707	52707	52707	52707
R-squared	0.220	0.217	0.208	0.221	0.202	0.188	0.243	0.198
FE: Group	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
FE: Biennium	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
FE: State	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001
Standard errors clustered by group.

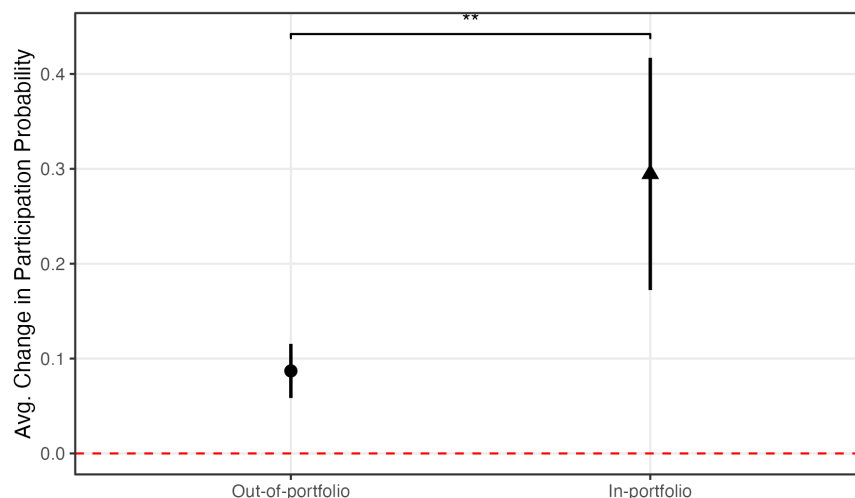


Figure E-3: **Comparison of Average Marginal Effect of Increased Electoral Competition by Group Type.** Points show the average change in the predicted probability that a group takes a position on election legislation associated with an increase in electoral competition from 0.5 to 1. Brackets indicate tests of equality between estimates for in- and out-of-portfolio groups (+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$).

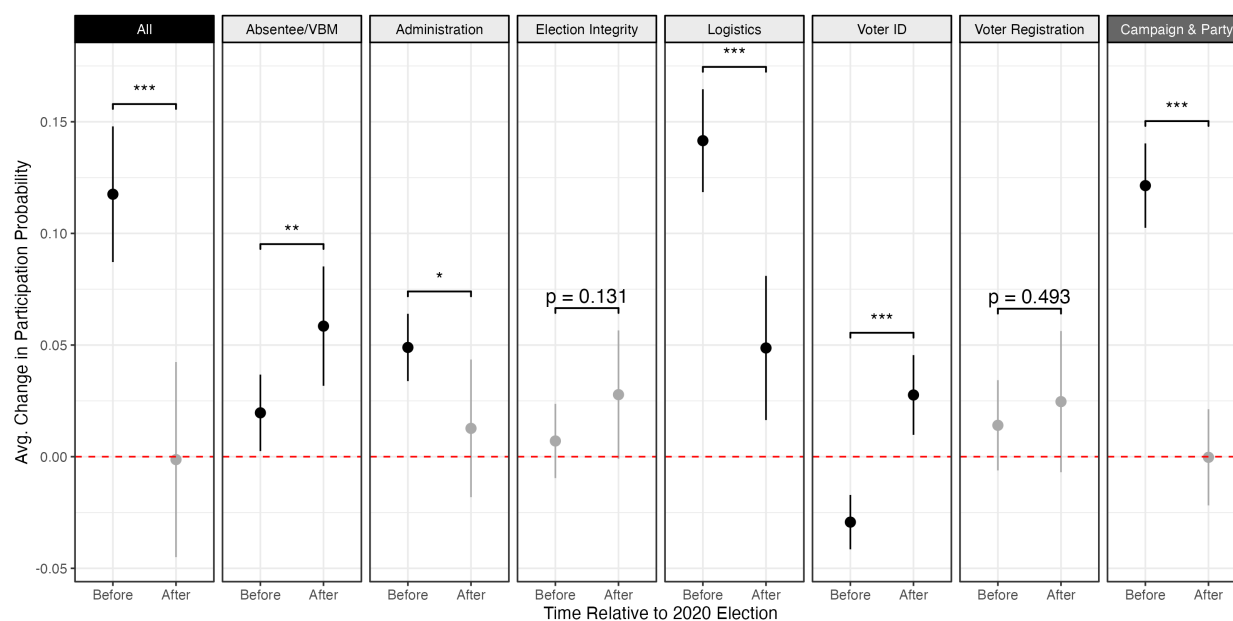


Figure E-4: **Average Marginal Effect of Increased Electoral Competition on Out-of-Portfolio Group Participation.** Points show the average change in the predicted probability that a group takes a position on election legislation associated with an increase in electoral competition from 0.5 to 1. The first panel reports effects pooled across all election legislation; subsequent panels report effects by policy area. Brackets indicate tests of equality between pre- and post-2020 estimates (+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$).

Table E-6: **Effects of Organizational Capacity, Presence, and Frustration on Out-of-Portfolio Group Participation in Election Policy**

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Log Revenue	0.005+ (0.003)	0.005 (0.006)	
Log Assets			0.004 (0.007)
Lag log(Positions) (Presence)		0.058*** (0.007)	0.058*** (0.007)
Lag Success Rate (Frustration)		0.017 (0.016)	0.017 (0.016)
N	15 669	7125	7125
R-squared	0.259	0.351	0.350
FE: Group	X	X	X
FE: Biennium	X	X	X
FE: State	X	X	X

+ p <0.1, * p <0.05, ** p <0.01, *** p <0.001

Standard errors clustered by group. Revenue and assets data collected from IRS 990 forms compiled by Proublica.

Table E-7: **Predictors of Election Lobbying Activity Among Out-of-Portfolio Groups in Wisconsin**

	Entry		Prop. Allocated		log(Hours)	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Lag Success Rate	-0.037* (0.017)	-0.026 (0.017)	-0.009 (0.006)	-0.006 (0.006)	-0.118** (0.045)	-0.092* (0.045)
Lag log(Total Hours)	-0.005 (0.005)	-0.008+ (0.005)	-0.001 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)	-0.009 (0.017)	-0.015 (0.017)
Lag log(Total Positions)	0.017+ (0.010)	0.013 (0.009)	0.001 (0.004)	0.000 (0.004)	0.033 (0.032)	0.023 (0.029)
State Government: Republican Trifecta	0.034** (0.011)		0.005+ (0.003)		0.077** (0.027)	
N	2356	2356	2163	2163	2356	2356
R-squared	0.518	0.545	0.337	0.351	0.304	0.326
FE: Group	X	X	X	X	X	X
FE: Biennium		X		X		X

+ p <0.1, * p <0.05, ** p <0.01, *** p <0.001

Standard errors clustered by group.

E.2 Do Groups Take Expected Positions on Election Legislation?

Table E-8: **Group Ideology Predicts Net Position Direction on Election Legislation**

	All Groups	Out-of-Portfolio	In-Portfolio
Group Ideology	0.067*** (0.003)	0.065*** (0.004)	0.081*** (0.008)
N	2139	1909	230
R-squared	0.153	0.133	0.330

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table E-9: **Predictors of Supporting Election Legislation**

	Expansive/Improves	Restrictive/Worsens	Mixed/Unclear
Group Ideology (SD)	-0.233*** (0.070)	0.497*** (0.107)	0.180 (0.137)
Democratic Trifecta x Group Ideology (SD)	0.064 (0.077)	-0.110 (0.160)	-0.356* (0.152)
Republican Trifecta x Group Ideology (SD)	0.342*** (0.103)	-0.031 (0.137)	0.119 (0.154)
N	4908	2831	1917
R-squared	0.639	0.561	0.701
FE: Legislation	X	X	X
FE: Biennium	X	X	X

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Standard errors clustered by group and legislation ID.

Table E-10: The Effect of Legislative Frustration on Supporting Expansion versus Restriction
Among Out-of-Portfolio Groups

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Lag Success Rate		0.033 (0.044)	0.166** (0.057)
Group Ideology (SD)	−0.335*** (0.048)	−0.309** (0.104)	−0.455*** (0.068)
Lag Success Rate × Group Ideology (SD)			0.357*** (0.079)
Group Ideology (SD) × State Government: Democrat Trifecta	0.160** (0.060)	0.154 (0.114)	
Group Ideology (SD) × State Government: Republican Trifecta	0.011 (0.072)	−0.041 (0.120)	
N	7739	5345	5345
R-squared	0.575	0.579	0.583
FE: Legislation	X	X	X
FE: Biennium	X	X	X

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Standard errors clustered by group and legislation ID.

E.3 How Does Group Participation Shape Legislative Outcomes?

Table E-11: Effects on Party Differentiation

	Main	Ideology	2-Sided	1-Sided	Non-Final	Pre-Voting
Prop. Out-of-Portfolio	0.059*	0.005	−0.009	−0.069	0.057	0.061
	(0.027)	(0.094)	(0.114)	(0.056)	(0.040)	(0.056)
Diff. Positions	0.149***				0.138***	0.197**
	(0.038)				(0.033)	(0.047)
Bipartisan	−0.174***	−0.172***	−0.233**	−0.149***	−0.163***	−0.231***
	(0.025)	(0.030)	(0.057)	(0.029)	(0.036)	(0.027)
Bill Type: Restrictive/Worsens	0.186**	0.205**	0.158*	0.154**	0.161**	0.275**
	(0.058)	(0.066)	(0.072)	(0.047)	(0.046)	(0.065)
Bill Type: Expansive/Improves	0.062	0.046	0.008	0.044	0.049	0.086
	(0.059)	(0.057)	(0.061)	(0.056)	(0.063)	(0.090)
Avg. Out-of-Portfolio Group Ideology		−0.015**		−0.014*		
		(0.004)		(0.005)		
Diff. in. Support/Oppose Avg. Group Ideology			0.044***			
			(0.008)			
N	1165	1006	317	687	1163	406
R-squared	0.410	0.404	0.495	0.410	0.374	0.464
FE: State	X	X	X	X	X	X
FE: Biennium	X	X	X	X	X	X

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001
Standard errors clustered by state.

Table E-12: Effects on Probability of Enactment

	Main	Ideology	2-Sided	1-Sided
Prop. Out-of-Portfolio	0.024 (0.024)	0.049 (0.037)	0.008 (0.079)	0.070 (0.042)
Diff. Positions	−0.038 (0.041)			
Bipartisan	0.091* (0.034)	0.083* (0.030)	0.166*** (0.032)	0.056 (0.035)
Bill Type: Restrictive/Worsens	−0.120*** (0.025)	−0.122** (0.034)	−0.107** (0.036)	−0.112** (0.036)
Bill Type: Expansive/Improves	−0.028 (0.029)	−0.023 (0.038)	−0.013 (0.036)	−0.023 (0.041)
Avg. Out-of-Portfolio Group Ideology		−0.004 (0.012)		−0.007 (0.012)
Diff. in. Support/Oppose Avg. Group Ideology			−0.019* (0.008)	
State Government: Democratic Trifecta	0.083* (0.034)	0.079* (0.035)	0.013 (0.049)	0.101* (0.041)
State Government: Republican Trifecta	−0.028 (0.036)	−0.042 (0.042)	−0.009 (0.069)	−0.056+ (0.030)
N	3163	2657	673	1981
R-squared	0.174	0.161	0.167	0.190
FE: State	X	X	X	X
FE: Biennium	X	X	X	X

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001
Standard errors clustered by state.

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